

FOURTH SERIES
VOL. 130
No. 19



THURSDAY
20TH NOVEMBER, 2025

PARLIAMENTARY DEBATES

OFFICIAL REPORT

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*Published by the Office of Chamber Reporting
Parliament House, Osu, Accra.*

*Designed and Printed by the Publishing Department
Parliament House, Osu, Accra.*

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THE
PARLIAMENT OF THE REPUBLIC
OF GHANA

THIRD MEETING, 2025

Thursday, 20th November, 2025

*The House met at the Chamber,
Parliament House, at 12:57 p.m.*

[HON FIRST DEPUTY SPEAKER,
MR BERNARD AHIAFOR, IN THE
CHAIR]

[PRAYERS]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we will go straight to the item numbered 5, Correction of *Votes and Proceedings* and the *Official Report*.

**VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND
THE
OFFICIAL REPORT**

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we have two *Votes and Proceedings*; the *Votes and Proceedings* of 21st October, 2025 and 19th November, 2025. Hon Members, let us first take that of 21st October, 2025.

Page 1...3. *[Pause]*

Hon Members, sorry, that of 21st October, 2025 is rather the agenda; it is not supposed to be adopted. So, let us move on to the *Vote and Proceedings* of 19th November, 2025.

Page 1— Yes, Hon Member, let me hear you.

Mr Alhassan Umar: We do not have that of 19th November, 2025 on the console. We only have that of 18th November, 2025 on the console.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Is it on the console? Well, it is actually the *Votes and Proceedings* for Wednesday, 19th November, 2025; the heading is wrong but the contents are the same. I think that there was a mistake while uploading it on the console.

With reference to the same document, page 1...11? Yes, Mr Frank Afriyie?

Mr Frank Afriyie: Mr Speaker, thank you so much.

Mr Speaker, respectfully, the Question numbered 376, the page numbered 11, on the very last paragraph, my surname has been wrongly spelled.

Then, consequentially, on the page numbered 12, the Question numbered 379—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Table, please take note.

Page 13— Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Vincent Ekow Assafuah: Mr Speaker, with the greatest of respect, I may have to bring you back to the page numbered 7. Respectfully, I have been marked absent, but I was here briefly yesterday; I signed and left—*[Interruption]*. Yes, please.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: That is why they marked you absent. You are supposed to be here. You are not supposed to sign and leave the House. Table, take note.

Page 13...14. Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Afriyie: Mr Speaker, this is just a minor observation. On the item numbered 10, I think just one Statement was made. So, if the heading could reflect it as such, that is, the Budget Statement and Economic Policy— But the heading is “STATEMENTS”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Normally, if you have Statements and you only take one Statement, the heading will reflect Statements, but not Statement. There are other Statements on the *Order Paper*, but they were all not exhausted. So, that must be captured in the *Votes and Proceedings*.

Mr Afriyie: Mr Speaker, thank you. We take the cue.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Page 15...33.

Hon Members, the *Votes and Proceedings* of Wednesday, 19th November, 2025, as presented and corrected, is hereby adopted as the true record of proceedings.

Hon Members, the *Official Reports*.

We have *Official Reports* of Tuesday, 11th November, 2025 and Wednesday, 12th November, 2025.

Let us start with Tuesday, 11th November, 2025.

Hon Members, it is before you for corrections. Hon Members, any corrections?

[No correction was made to the Official Report of Tuesday, 11th November, 2025]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Now, *Official Report* of 12th November, 2025.

Hon Members, any corrections?

[No correction was made to the Official Report of Wednesday, 12th November, 2025]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the next item is item numbered 6 — Questions.

Yes, Hon Deputy Majority Leader?

1:07 p.m.

Deputy Majority Leader (Mr George Kweku Ricketts-Hagan): Mr Speaker, thank you. The Hon Minister is here to answer Questions stated in the item numbered 6. We can start with the Questions.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, may I then invite the Minister for Food and Agriculture to take the designated seat?

Yes, Minority Chief Whip?

Minority Chief Whip (Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh): Mr Speaker, I think

it is instructive for us to acknowledge that the agreement is that the focus will be on the debate, so we will proceed to take Questions, but the follow-ups will be limited to one per Member.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much, Hon Minority Chief Whip. So, we should all take note accordingly; that was the agreement.

Hon Members, may I call on Hon Kwame Dzudzorli Gakpey to ask Question numbered 429. Yes, Hon Frank Afriyie?

Mr Frank Afriyie: Mr Speaker, thank you. I have his authorisation to ask the Question on his behalf.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please do. Thank you.

ORAL ANSWERS TO QUESTIONS

MINISTRY OF FOOD AND AGRICULTURE

Utilisation of Funds Received to Combat Drought in Northern Ghana

Mr Frank Afriyie on behalf of Mr Kwame Dzudzorli Gakpey (NDC — Keta): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Food and Agriculture how much funds Ghana has received from international organisations to combat drought in the northern part of Ghana and how it has been utilised?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much, Hon Member. Yes, Hon Minister, you have the floor.

Minister for Food and Agriculture (Mr Eric Opoku) (MP): Mr Speaker, a total amount of US\$81.92 million has been secured for agricultural inputs. This funding is provided by the World Bank under its Food Systems Resilience Program (FSRP).

The breakdown of the fund usage which was used exclusively to procure vital agricultural inputs (fertiliser and seeds) for farmers in the drought-affected regions in Ghana including Northern regions is as follows:

No.	Items	QTY (MT)	Cost (USD)	Percentage of Total Cost
1.	Fertiliser (NPK & Urea)	117,188.0	75,000,320	91.55 per cent
2.	Seeds (Rice & Maize)	3,266.5	6,919,500	8.45 per cent
	Grand Total	120,454.5	81,919,820	100 per cent

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary questions?

Mr Frank Afriyie: Mr Speaker, no. Thank you very much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Jerry Ahmed Shaib?

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib: Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity. I want to ask the respected Minister for Food and Agriculture that with all this expenditure, can he assure us that drought in the Northern part of Ghana is going to reduce drastically?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Eric Opoku: Mr Speaker, this expenditure was incurred before we assumed office on 7th January, 2025. It was part of the drought mitigating measures implemented by the previous Government. This money was used principally to procure fertilisers and seed. We certainly cannot use fertilizer and seed to reduce drought. But if the Hon Member is asking about specific interventions we are putting in place today to reduce the impact of drought in the north, then I will tell him that we are doing a lot of irrigation infrastructure. We are providing solar-powered boreholes to ensure all year-round production in the northern enclave.

We are also constructing new dams and rehabilitating existing ones.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we then move to the Question numbered 273, standing in the name of Mr Richard Kuuire, MP for Nandom. You have the floor.

Establishment and Operationalisation of Farmers Services Centre in Nandom

Mr Richard Kuuire (NDC—Nandom): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Food and Agriculture when the Farmers Services Centre at the Nandom Constituency will be established and made operational?

Mr Eric Opoku: Mr Speaker, I think this is the second time I am answering this Question. The other time this same Question appeared and I came here to answer it but let me repeat the Answer.

Mr Speaker, efforts are underway for the establishment of Farm Service Centres (FSC) in all agricultural districts in the country to offer unimpeded access to mechanisation, quality seeds, fertilisers, extension services delivery among others to our valuable farmers in these districts.

Mr Speaker, the Ministry is aware that Nandom Constituency is an agricultural district and will certainly benefit from this facility.

Mr Speaker, in line with above, I wish to assure this august House that the Nandom Constituency will have its fair share of the facility as soon as the procurement processes are completed.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary?

Mr Kuuire: Mr Speaker, I have a supplementary question. I want to ask the Minister whether the Nandom District will be among the first 50 districts to benefit.

Mr Eric Opoku: Mr Speaker, the first 50 districts have been selected already. Documentations on the land for the facility have been concluded. We are now compiling the second list. I will check, if Nandom is not in the first list, certainly they will be in the second list.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, this is a constituency-specific Question. Let us move to the Question numbered 342, standing in the name of Hon Ida Adjoa Asiedu, Member of Parliament for Ayensuano. Hon Member, you have the floor.

Capacity Building Programmes for Farmers

Ms Ida Adjoa Asiedu (NPP—Ayensuano): Mr Speaker, I beg ask the Minister for Food and Agriculture what training or capacity-building programmes are available for farmers to improve their skills and knowledge on modern farming practices? Thank you.

Mr Eric Opoku: Mr Speaker, a variety of training and capacity-building programmes are programmed for farmers, through the Directorate of Agricultural Extension and Agricultural

Engineering Services Directorate of the Ministry to farmers, aimed at enhancing their skills and knowledge in modern farming practices.

Mr Speaker, some trainings are often delivered through farm and home visits, complemented by workshops with hands-on field practice to ensure practical learning and adoption of technologies.

Mr Speaker, Directorate of Agriculture Extension of the Ministry has outlined the following trainings some of which are on-going:

1. Preparation and utilisation of compost and biochar for soil health improvement.
2. Use of blended fertiliser for tomato cultivation to increase productivity.
3. Construction of improved poultry and livestock housing structures for enhanced productivity.
4. Formulation of nutritious feed for poultry and small ruminants.
5. Inoculation of soybean seeds with Rhizobium to boost nitrogen fixation and improve yields.
6. Soil conservation practices, e.g., minimum tillage, cover cropping, intercropping, mulching, crop rotation, *et cetera*.
7. Safe use of agrochemicals.

8. Correct fertiliser application methods and rate.
9. Preparation of multi-nutritional feed block for small ruminants.
10. Compost making and application.
11. Nursery layout and seedling transplanting.
12. Pest control demonstration (IPM).
13. Harvesting, sorting, and grading.
14. Post-harvest handling to reduce spoilage.
15. Compost preparation and organic fertiliser use.
16. Pest and disease scouting using sticky traps.
17. Safe use of agrochemicals and personal protective equipment (PPE).
18. Integrated Pest Management (IPM).

1:17 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, any supplementary question?

Ms Asiedu: Mr Speaker, I am grateful to the Hon Minister for answering my Question. Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us move to the Question numbered 425, standing in the name of Mr Richmond Edem Kofi Kpotosu, Member of Parliament (MP) for Ho Central.

Projected Number of Months of Food Security in Case of a Global Pandemic

Mr Richmond Edem Kofi Kpotosu (NDC — Ho Central): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Food and Agriculture the Ministry's projected number of months for food security in case of a global pandemic.

Mr Eric Opoku: Mr Speaker, in general terms, a pandemic is an epidemic of an infectious disease that has a sudden increase in cases and spreads across a large region, for instance, multiple continents or worldwide, affecting a substantial portion of the human population.

Mr Speaker, food security is multi-dimensional (availability, access, utilisation, stability). Any projection of "months of food security" depends heavily on baseline stocks, supply chains, trade, and response capacity. Also, to specifically estimate a plausible month for food security, in case of a global pandemic, depends on figures of Ghana's agricultural production, import

dependency, reserve stocks, and pandemic risk factors.

Mr Speaker, based on the international standard for strategic grain reserves of governments ensuring availability of food stock for 3–6 months (sometimes up to 12) planning, Mr Speaker, the Government of Ghana has resourced the National Food Buffer Stock Company (NAFCO) to procure the excess grains for storage as a natural strategy to address any food shortage and also ensure revenue for farmers.

Mr Speaker, I also wish to state that the government of Ghana has further pledged commitment in its 2026 Budget for the same activity for NAFCO.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, any supplementary question?

Mr Kpotosu: Mr Speaker, I am grateful that the Hon Minister has spoken to my Question. Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we then move to the Question numbered 464, standing in the name of Mr Akwasi Gyamfi Onyina-Acheampong, MP for Kwabre East.

Yes, Mr Jerry Shaib?

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib: Mr Speaker, with due deference to you, if I am

permitted, I have his authority to ask the Question —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Once you have his authority, you can go ahead.

Sustainable Prices for Actors in the Cocoa Value Chain

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib on behalf of Mr Akwasi Gyamfi Onyina-Acheampong (NPP — Kwabre East): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Food and Agriculture the plans of the Ministry to ensure sustainable prices for actors in the cocoa value chain, including farmers, licensed buying companies and transporters.

Mr Eric Opoku: Mr Speaker, the last time I appeared here, a Question on cocoa was posed to me, and I clearly indicated the position of this House on that matter. Probably, I may have to repeat it for the record and to also let our Colleagues understand that Ghana Cocoa Board (COCOBOD) is no longer under the Ministry of Food and Agriculture, in consonance with the law passed by this House. So, I cannot understand why Parliament will ask me to come here and respond to a Question relating to an agency not under my Ministry. At least, Parliament must be fair to me.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Do you have a supplementary question to this?

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, we are grateful to the Hon Minister.

Mr Speaker, save that, I think the Hon Minister respectfully, is also not being fair to you and some of us. To the extent that admission of Questions is the total prerogative of the Speaker, therefore, even if there is some identification of problems with the Question, respectfully, I think that is within the remit of the Speaker. So, it is not totally us; we are all part of the process. Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Mr Jerry Shaib, sometimes, if you ask Hon Members to redirect the Questions, they have a problem with you. We passed the law; which Hon Member of Parliament is not aware of the law that we passed, that COCOBOD is no longer under the Ministry of Agriculture?

Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Dominic Bingab Aduna Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, when a Question is filed to a Minister, the Minister is given notice 14 clear days before he appears in this House to answer the Question. In fact, it is the duty of the Minister to indicate to the Clerk to Parliament that a particular Question is not a Question under their Ministry, so they are not scheduled to ask the Question. So, if the Hon Minister has been scheduled, then there are two things; it is either he did not inform the

Clerk to Parliament, or that he was willing to come and answer the Question, which is why they have called him here.

Mr Speaker, as for the admissibility of Questions, if you feel that a Question is a good Question, you would administer it, which you did, but it is the duty of the Hon Minister to inform the Clerk to Parliament that the Question is not under his Ministry, therefore, he cannot provide an answer to it. With that, he would not be scheduled. This has always been the practice.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Mr Dominic Bingab Aduna Nitiwul, the Answer to the Question appears at page 11 of the *Order Paper*. So, having looked at the Answer, you can do the honourable thing by withdrawing the Question. If you are not convinced by the Answer, then you can proceed to ask the Question. So, the Hon Minister has brought his Answer to Parliament, which constitutes notice to Parliament, as well as the questioner.

Hon Minister, that being the last Question for you today, we thank you very much for attending upon the House and responding to all these Questions scheduled for you.

Thank you very much. You are hereby discharged.

Hon Members, we have dealt with the item numbered 6. We now move to the item numbered 7(a), commentary to continue.

Yes, Deputy Majority Leader?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, this is just a reminder that in conclave, we agreed as you have rightly said, but we also said that we have one commemorative Statement to be made, but that will be done at the end of the commentary.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Because we would do it at the end, that is why I did not mention it.

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Rightly so, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, we move to the item numbered 7(a). I then proceed to give the floor to Alhaji Alhassan Suhuyini. You have 15 minutes.

1:27 p.m.

STATEMENT

Government's Financial Policy, 2026

[Resumption of debate from 19/11/25]

Alhaji Suhuyini Sayibu Alhassan (NDC — Tamale North): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to the ongoing debate on the Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of

Ghana for the year 2026, presented by the Minister of Finance, on behalf of His Excellency the President.

Mr Speaker, I wish to, first of all, commend the Minister for Finance, Dr Cassiel Ato Baah Forson and his team for the yeoman's job that they have been doing for the people of Ghana, and I urge them to continue to make us proud.

Mr Speaker, this was a very simple-to-digest Budget, and it is out there and admitted by many, especially the experts, that the Minister for Finance was very honest about his accounts as far as the economy is concerned. He acknowledged the distressed economy that he inherited, and recounted to us how the 2025 Budget had helped to restore fiscal stability. He also accounted to this House, how the fiscal stability was being sustained through the introduction of revenue reforms that were to ensure more tax compliance, especially with the introduction of digital means of collecting revenue such as the introduction of Artificial Intelligence (AI). What was also most significant was his emphasis on tighter expenditure controls and the growth-orientated spending that he and his team have been focusing on. If you look at page 141 to 142, you would realise that the resource allocations that are outlined are indeed growth-orientated allocations that will help to spur the economy on.

Mr Speaker, I have followed the debate in the last couple of days, and I would say that it has been amazing watching our Colleagues on the other Side, exhibit what seemed like the height

of hypocrisy and stunning display of collective amnesia—[Uproar]—It is amazing to watch them lament about unemployment and poverty while criticising the focus of this Government on critical infrastructure. For eight long years, they were the very architects of our current economic distress. [Hear! Hear!] They were in charge, and presided over an era where the word “corruption” became synonymous with leadership: from the Agyapa Royalties deals to the Aker Energy controversies to the PDS scandals, the countless reported breaches on the COVID-19 Relief Fund of about GHC21 billion, the National Cathedral waste of over about US\$100 million, the SkyTrain deals that never was, the Pwalugu Multipurpose Dam that never was, and the money that the State lost as a result of these ventures. I could go on and on.

Mr Speaker, their tenure was a master class of state capture. The resources that should have been building factories, that should have been building schools, that should have been building hospitals were instead funnelled into the pockets of a very selected few. So, when you watch them today lament about unemployment and poverty, it is shocking and can only be described as the height of hypocrisy.

Mr Speaker, yesterday I heard my Hon Colleague, Kojo Oppong Nkrumah, make reference to the fact that they handed over about 150 factories, and that because we have scrapped the 1D1F office, those factories cannot provide the jobs that are needed. Really! Was the 1D1F factory paying the workers? If indeed, they handed over 150 factories,

those factories should be providing the jobs and contributing to the economy of this country, whether a 1D1F office is in existence or not. Whether a 1D1F office is in existence or not should not affect the running of those 150 factories. They say in Dagbani that, *ka yaa nye tizuyu milgi ya*, to wit, the lack of energy to carry the load that is before you, is the reason why you will say the aid that is to help you carry the load has shifted. So, clearly, if they had those 150 factories, they would have been functioning and supporting the economy.

Mr Speaker, the culture of corruption that directly fuelled unemployment and poverty they now pretend to decry can only be attributed to their Administration. How can jobs be created when contract sums were inflated? The funds were actually channelled— We were told in this country that *party hia sika*. We witnessed what happened when they introduced the Livelihood Empowerment Against Poverty (LEAP) programme; we witnessed what happened when they introduced Nation Builders’ Corps (NABCO). These schemes were compromised by systematic grafts leaving beneficiaries in the lurch. The lamentations, therefore, are not a sudden awakening of conscience. They are a political strategy just to evade responsibility. But I assure them that President Mahama and his Government will ensure that every pesewa that was wasted is retrieved where possible.

Mr Speaker, the priority of this Government is on critical infrastructure, and critical infrastructure, is not just

luxury. It is a necessary intervention to rebuild the foundation that they destroyed. Their administration prioritised consumption, spending on themselves and their cronies while this Government is prioritising production. One cannot tackle unemployment without reliable energy. Investing in the power grid and renewable energy is what will power the industries that will create the jobs and that is why in this Budget, you will notice the commitment to a GPP2, the construction of another Ghana gas processing factory.

Mr Speaker, you cannot reduce poverty without efficient transport system. Building roads, and port infrastructure is what will lower the cost of food and goods, and connect farmers to markets and make Ghanaian businesses competitive. And that is why, you will notice in this Budget, again, that we have prioritised critical road corridors in this country. We have prioritised the construction of the Western Corridor, Wenchi all the way to Wa; the Eastern Corridor that will take the road all the way from Aflao to the Upper East Region, Kulungugu. We have also prioritised the Central Corridor, and as we speak, the dualisation of the Accra-Kumasi highway has reached about 64 per cent completion rate. Mr Speaker, you would recall that when we came into power, that project was stalled because there was no dedicated funding for that project. It has been put now on the Big Push agenda. The headline of President Mahama's Big Push agenda is the new expressway that will see about eight interchanges on the Kumasi-Accra

highway. Mr Speaker, all of these are not just concrete, bitumen and metals. These are projects that will impact our economy, that will produce jobs, and that will create employment.

Mr Speaker, you cannot attract investment without a transparent system. The new Government, His Excellency President Mahama's Government, is focused on rebuilding trust and directing funds into tangible projects. And these projects, Mr Speaker, will ensure that we restore the confidence that is required for the necessary investments to be made to bring about the jobs.

1:37 p.m.

Mr Speaker, finally, I heard the former Minister for Finance, Hon Amin Adam, yesterday, also make reference to food inflation, and peddled data that was questionable. I say so because he was referring to the Ghana Statistical Service report. Clearly, what he was quoting could not have been from the Ghana Statistical Service. According to the Statistical Service, Ghana's food inflation has significantly decreased in 2025, dropping from a peak of 23.8 per cent in December to 14.8 per cent this year. Clearly, it shows that this is a substantial reduction of 9 per cent decrease over the period, with a trend continuing with a year-on-year inflation. This is from the Statistical Service website.

So, for the former Minister for Finance to have claimed that food prices were going up, clearly, and referencing the Statistical Service, could not have been a correct reflection of the true state of events.

Mr Speaker, when I speak of this Government investing in critical areas that will bring about employment and reduce poverty, I am talking about the Minister for Finance's assurance that about GH¢245 million is going to be made available to the Ministry of Food and Agriculture to ensure that we improve the agro-industrial value chains covering feed Ghana. Mr Speaker, I also refer to the GH¢6.9 billion oil palm finance window that will support the implementation of the national policy on integrated oil palm.

Mr Speaker, I speak of the No-Fee-Stress Policy, which will continue and will be allocated GH¢537 million this year. I speak of the GH¢25 million for free tertiary for persons with disabilities. These are the growth-oriented spending that the Minister for Finance seeks to lead his team to implement in the 2026 Budget.

I, therefore, call on our Friends to drop the height of hypocrisy and join us in approving this Budget for His Excellency the President to build the bridge and provide the ladder that will help us climb out of the abyss they left this country only about a year ago. I thank you very much. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you, Hon Member.

Hon Members, can we listen to each other in silence? It is now the turn of Mr Dominic Bingab Aduna Nitiwul. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Dominic Bingab Aduna Nitiwul (NPP — Bimbilla): Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, my good Friend opposite the aisle just spoke as if he were in opposition, but he has moved into Government. He is no more in opposition. He should bring us the hard evidence of the corruption he is talking about and stop lamenting. The lamentations will not help them. They lamented for eight years. They are in Government, and they are still lamenting. Stop the lamentations and work.

Mr Speaker, I hold in my hands—
[*Expunged by order of Mr Speaker*]

Mr Speaker, if one makes promises and does not fulfil them, the next time, the person goes to make even more promises, nobody will listen to that person. That is the reason Ghanaians are not listening to them. They should take their time and read the Budget. I have given them the promises that they made. If they do not have time to read the entire Budget, I have made it easy for them. They should go and check; they will see all of them.

Mr Speaker, what is worse off is that my Friends opposite the aisle from 2019, for five good years, made hell and a fetish out of buying and retooling the military. They insulted the former President and my good self. Some of them, led by the Minister for Foreign Affairs, became experts in aviation overnight. Mr Speaker, today, they have come and under paragraph 1091 of the Budget Statement and Economic Policy, say that they want to buy one long-range aircraft and one medium-range aircraft.

Mr Speaker, even to accept that they are intending to buy VIP and executive jets, they are running away from it. We have two types of aircraft that are controlled and operated by the military. The first is the executive aircraft and the second is the military aircraft. A medium-range military aircraft includes CASA C-295— *[Interruption]*.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Gakpey, please. Hon Members, let us listen to each other in silence.

Mr Nitiwul: Then C-90—Mr Speaker—**[Some Hon Members:** Senior o!! Senior!!]

[Expunged by order of Mr Speaker]

Mr Speaker, the military of Ghana already has three medium-size ranged aircrafts. For the long-range aircraft, it includes heavy bombers like B2, large transport aircraft.

[Expunged by order of Mr Speaker]

Some Hon Members: Senior o!! Senior!!

Mr Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, Ghana does not need and cannot operate, and no African country operates a long-range military aircraft. It only leaves us with one option, what we call the VIP aircraft.

[Expunged by order of Mr Speaker]

Some Hon Members: Ei!

Mr Nitiwul: Mr Speaker—*[Expunged by order of Mr Speaker]*

I say this, I can never be against the purchase and retooling of the military, never. After eight years, I will never be against it. In fact, I was here to fight for the military to get aircrafts. I will never, and can never be against it. But my Colleagues on the opposite Side need to explain to the people of Ghana why, for five years, they fought against it, and nine months later, they are running to buy not one, but two.

1:47 p.m.

Mr Speaker, they need to do that and possibly apologise to the people of Ghana. Let me be very frank, if you have GH¢9 billion—When you check the 2025 Budget, and check the commitments in the budget for 2026, 2027 and 2028, the total budget is GH¢9 billion. **[Some Hon Members:** Eii!] Mr

Speaker that is what has been committed to retool the Ghana Air Force.

[Expunged by order of Mr Speaker]

Mr Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, if you have GH¢9 billion in three years to spend on the Ghana Air Force, go like we first did and procure one fighter jet for the military. That is what the military needs first. It is the reason why I came to this House, to lay the procurement of six LNG new generation fighter jets for the military. That programme is still there. The only reason those jets have not arrived is because we entered into an International Monetary Fund (IMF) programme, and all the funding banks stopped paying.

Mr Speaker, I say to you that if you talk to every soldier, every Air Force officer or every pilot, that if Government has GH¢9 billion, the first thing they will tell you is to buy for them and what they need to be able to protect the people of Ghana— What they need to protect the people of Ghana is a helicopter gunship and fighter jets first. If you decide to— *[Expunged by order of Mr Speaker]*— you are buying it for your own comfort, the comfort of the Executive. That is one.

I am telling you the truth. I am not saying do not buy it. The military needs it. Go ahead and buy, but at least buy one.

Mr Ayariga — rose —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Nitiwul, may I recognise the Majority Leader.

Majority Leader (Mr Mahama Ayariga): Mr Speaker, I have been trying for quite a while to get your attention, to catch your eye, because a very senior Member of this House who was a frontbench Member and a leader for a long time is doing something that I thought we need your guidance on. In the Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government, 2026, there is mention made of retooling the Air Force and budgetary allocations. He, without this Parliament being given specifications regarding exactly what type of aircrafts the Air Force will be purchasing, has gone— He is seeking to lay those as official records when the Budget Statement and Economic Financial Policy of the Government, 2026, has not provided any specification; short, medium or long-range aircrafts are going to be purchased for the Air Force. That is why I was trying to catch your attention, Mr Speaker, that he cannot be allowed to display those and to lay those as part of the official records because it is not contained in the Budget. The specifications are not mentioned. He is only anticipating, and our rules are clear on anticipation.

Since the budgetary allocation is being made, definitely when the Minister for Finance or the Minister for Defence now goes to procure these items, because they will be international transactions, they will be brought to this House. In this House we will see specifically what is being procured to retool the Air Force. I

can understand his displeasure and unhappiness that during his term he could not succeed in getting this House to procure those items. I can understand, but it is no basis for breaching the rules on anticipation. Do not anticipate. Wait, the agreements will come to this House. Whether it is a presidential jet, or whichever type of aircraft, it is this House that is going to consider and approve it. At that time, we can engage in the debate that the Hon Member is engaging today. But for today, the Hon Member cannot be specific and try to indicate that we are—of this description because nothing like that is mentioned in the Budget.

I can understand that that whole Side of the House has seen nothing wrong with this Budget and thinks that a—*[Expunged by order of Mr Speaker]*—is enough to rally people against this Budget. I can assure the Hon Member that—*[Expunged by order of Mr Speaker]*—is not enough to rally Ghanaians against this very good Budget that is going to improve the welfare of Ghanaians.

Deputy Minority Leader (Ms Patricia Appiagyei): Mr Speaker, I actually rose to draw your attention to the fact that we did not know on what point of order the Majority Leader was speaking, and it looked like he was debating. It is not within our practice that we should go on that way.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, I will use the opportunity to deal with the issue.

Ms Appiagyei: No. The Majority Leader needed to rise on a point of order, and that is what we require.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I think we can look at the issue critically within the Budget.

I have seen similar—four of them, and all the—are similar with the same inscriptions. The inscriptions, as to why four of them are being tabled, the least said about it, the better. This is because they are the same.

Mr Nitiwul — *rose* —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Mr Nitiwul, let me finish. Now, the— I would want you to link it to the Budget under reference for us to admit it. Else, you would have to take—back.

Hon Members, the second issue. I have a—

Hon Members, I am not debating. I also want this particular document to be linked to the Budget under reference to make it admissible.

The other one is also long-range military with— Mr Nitiwul, my question to you is to link these ones to the Budget.

I also received a document which is not signed, and it purports to come from the 2025 Budget promise by Ministries. Hon Members, you have the 2025 Budget. What you can do is to take the specific promise and draw the attention of the House to the Budget under reference. I am accordingly returning the documents to you to do the needful.

1:57 p.m.

Mr Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, I am happy that this is live on TV. The people of Ghana are watching us.

Mr Speaker, first of all, it is either some people were not listening or they have just failed to listen. I said the military operates two types of aircrafts, they operate pure military aircraft— And I gave the House the description of the type of aircraft that we have. They also operate VIP aircraft. This is because in the Government's Budget Statement and Economic Policy, they said they were going to buy a medium-range aircraft and long-range aircraft. There are only two types they can buy; they can either buy a military aircraft or VIP aircraft. I took my time to educate them on what a medium-sized military aircraft is, with description. Mr Speaker, that is what I gave you. I also took my time to educate the House on what a long-range military aircraft is and that is what I gave to you Mr Speaker. I then concluded that Ghana

already has three medium-sized aircrafts so we do not need it and have never requested for three medium-sized military aircrafts.

I also said that no African country, in fact very few countries in the world, apart from about three or four are operating long-range military aircrafts. So, the Ghana Air Force has never and will never request for long-range military aircrafts. What they have requested for is the VIP aircraft and that is what I came here for. I am saying to them that they should be brave enough and accept that we are going to buy two presidential jets. I concluded by saying that I will never be against it and I have never been against it, but they are running away from it. Why? It is because of the politics of what they did. The politics of yesterday is making them run away from it. They did politics for five years against military aircrafts, but today, they are running away from it.

But I can tell them something, and let me repeat that I, who sat in that place for eight years knows the needs of the military better than anybody in this room. I agree that it is not in our interest as a nation not to have a strategic lift.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Nitiwul, I would ask that they stop your time for you. Let me listen to Hon Ayariga.

Mr Ayariga: Once again, my point is a simple one. There is a Budget Statement and Economic Policy before us that says "Retooling of the Air Force". There is nothing in it about a presidential jet. I recall that just about a year ago, Hon

Nitiwul was in this House to brief us on the need for this House to approve the purchase of a presidential jet because the existing ones were not fit for purpose. That was why the former President was hiring aircrafts and bathing in the air in aircrafts that had bathrooms. He was saying that there was a need for a presidential jet because the existing ones were not fit for purpose. I am saying that this Budget Statement and Economic Policy does not mention a presidential jet, but it talks about retooling the Air Force.

Our rules, in Order 125, and Mr Speaker, may I read;

“A Member shall not anticipate any matter by the consideration of a Motion dealing with the subject matter which is likely to be introduced in the Meeting.”

I am saying that once we approve this Budget Statement and Economic Policy, the details of what constitutes retooling of the Air Force will come to us. That Motion will come to us, so when it comes and it is a presidential jet, we will debate it. But as at now, there is nothing in the Budget Statement and Economic Policy about a presidential jet, so he cannot premise his debate on the anticipation that this Government might be considering the purchase of a presidential jet.

So, I plead with you that once again. I have noticed for the past three days that

the debates have all been about a presidential jet. That is the only point I hear from my friends in the Minority. It is a speaking point that almost everybody who gets up tries to hop on but it is not in the Budget Statement and Economic Policy.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Patrick Boamah?

Mr Patrick Yaw Boamah: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. The little knowledge I have is that every aircraft, be it a presidential jet that the Air Force or the military acquires, belongs to the fleet owned by the Ghana Air Force. So, whether it is a retooling of the Air Force or an acquisition of an aircraft for the use of the President, they are all aircrafts that are going to belong to the Ghana Air Force, including the presidential jet in question. So, there is nothing strange about the former Minister talking about retooling of the Air Force, including the acquisition of a presidential jet. I thank you very much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members with all due respect, the Budget Statement and Economic Policy is before all of us. I hear people from the background making reference to paragraph 1091, so let me read paragraph 1091.

“Mr Speaker, the Ghana Air Force will be retooled. Beginning 2026, the Government of Ghana will

begin the procurement processes for the acquisition of four modern helicopters, one long-range and one medium-range aircraft.”

Hon Members, we have always been saying that you cannot be wrong in using the constitutional language. In this case, you can also not be wrong in using the language in the Budget Statement and Economic Policy. So, please use the language in the Budget Statement and Economic Policy. When you want to quote paragraph 1091, quote it appropriately.

Mr Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, I was very careful and used the words “VIP transport”. I have not yet used the word “presidential jet” or maybe if I did, I did it once. But I am saying to the House that if there is anybody in this room who knows the needs of the military—I have sat there for eight years, and I am saying that I hold the same position I held last year and for the last eight years, that it is not in our interest as a country not to have a strategic lift. We need it.

I am saying the Government should own up. If they want to buy two, they should own up, apologise to the people of Ghana and go ahead to convince us why for the past five years, they rejected the purchase of one, yet today, they want to buy two; one long range and one medium-sized.

Mr Speaker, the teachers of this country yesterday, were demonstrating and they played the voice of the current President when he said to the teachers that he would post them automatically. Where is the automatic posting for teachers?

2:07 p.m.

Mr Speaker, they cannot even post the teachers. The NPP posted over 80,000 health personnel and over 60,000 education personnel over eight years. Yesterday, teachers were on demonstration and the nurses also did theirs. Why are they suffocating these two sectors when they promised them? Why? They promised to employ them, but why are they not employing them? They give teachers 6,000; the NPP gave them 10,000, yet they are refusing to employ them. What they are simply doing is employing what the NPP bequeathed to them.

Mr Speaker, let me state that if they had completed 1D1F, they would have employed in excess of 5,000 people. If they had completed Agenda 111, they would have been able to employ in excess of 3,000 to 4,000 people. Mr Speaker, I say to this Government that the only interest they have is in themselves. That is the interest they have. They are satisfying themselves, not the people of Ghana. This 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy is about satisfying themselves. That is what they are doing, and that is why they are buying things for their—*[Interruption]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, your time is up.

Hon Member, clearly, any time there is an interruption, I ask that they should stop your time, and accordingly, they have been stopping your time. I announce it because I do not control the time. So, I normally announce.

Hon Members, before proceeding to acknowledge our guests, let me indicate that I have given the opportunity to Mr Dominic Bingab Aduna Nitiwul to link the pictures and other documents to the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy under reference. He has not been able to do so.

Hon Members, on that note, having not linked the pictures and other write-ups to the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, I would order that anything said about the pictures as well as the documents should all be expunged from our records as if they do not exist.

Hon Members, I have also looked at the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy carefully, and I have not seen any picture in it. I find it very difficult to establish a nexus between the pictures and the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy. Accordingly, it should be expunged.

I proceed to acknowledge the presence of Worldwide Council of Clergy, led by Most Rev Dr Felix, the Presiding Bishop. They are from New Juaben South Constituency. They are 32 in number.

We also have Prince KKMA No. 1 Junior High School, led by Sarah Boatemaa, Assistant Headteacher from

Kpone-Katamanso Municipal. They are 70 in number.

We also have Prince KKMA No. 2 Junior High School, led by Raphael Teye Manyabi, the Assistant Headteacher. They are also from Kpone-Katamanso and they are 70 in number.

[Members of the Worldwide Council of Clergy were acknowledged]

[Pupils of Prince KKMA No. 1 Junior High School were acknowledged]

[Pupils of Prince KKMA No. 2 Junior High School were acknowledged]

STATEMENT

Government's Financial Policy, 2026

[Resumption of debate from Column 37]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, on your behalf, I welcome them to the Parliament of the Republic of Ghana. You are welcome. May you have a very fruitful stay.

Hon Members, next on the list is Hajia Laadi Ayii Ayamba. **[Some Hon Members: Eii!!]**

You have 15 minutes.

Hajia Laadi Ayii Ayamba (NDC — Pusiga): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

I rise to comment on the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy

presented to this House by the Minister for Finance on behalf of the President of the Republic of Ghana, H.E. John Dramani Mahama.

Mr Speaker, going through the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, and listening to my Colleagues, I can only allude to the fact that indeed, this Budget is for resetting growth, jobs, and economic transformation.

Mr Speaker, what took my breath away in the Budget, first of all, was the issue of our education. For the past eight years, before this current Government came into office, all we heard was free education and changing times for going to school, especially the secondary schools. Their time for going to school was like traffic lights. Students either spent only two or three weeks in school, came back, and then had to go back. It was quite devastating for both students and parents.

In order to reset, we have gone back. In this 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, it is clearly stated on page 142, paragraph 1150, which looks at the basic level of education. Mr Speaker, we are quite aware that most people struggle because at the basic level, they do not have the right infrastructure to support them. Mr Speaker, on paragraph 1150, if I may read, it states that:

“We have also allocated GHC3 billion for:

- four (4) sets of KG books and workbooks for about 200,000 learners;

- four (4) sets of primary textbooks for 2 million learners; and
- nine (9) sets of JHS 3 textbooks for 500,000 learners; and
- procurement of over 2 million pieces of metal mono-desks and chairs, 200 units of 66-seater buses, and 200 double-cabin pick-ups for distribution to secondary schools across the country.”

Mr Speaker, if we look at this aspect of the Budget, one would realise that we are picking up the foundation as expected of us.

2:17 p.m.

After the National Democratic Congress (NDC) Government exited office, right from 2016, we never heard much. The Schools Under Trees Programme, more or less came to a standstill. Up till now, especially, when you go to the villages, you will find a lot of schools that do not have classrooms; they have no furniture. So, to go back to do this, is in the right direction.

Mr Speaker, allocation has been made for this activity to take place. It is very interesting for some of us to sit here and listen with rapt attention that our Colleagues on the opposite Side, will argue and raise everything that they think they can against the current Government,

after only being in governance for just nine months—[*Interruption*].

Mr Speaker, I do not know whether they know when they exited; it is very interesting. The issue of *galamsey* has been on their lips as if they left governance 40 years ago. Have we so soon forgotten about the Committee Report that was produced by the Prof Frimpong Boateng Committee? Have we so soon forgotten that, in this country we heard people refuse to even give attention to that Report. Not to talk of saying that they will even punish those who were found culpable.

Today, we are talking about *galamsey* and alluding to the fact that it is an issue that this current Government should take up very seriously, when they had just left government. What did they do? Actually, this Government is taking it up very seriously. Because, they can see the number of people who are being held for misbehaviour when it comes to the issue of *galamsey*.

We all know the kinds of forests that have been destroyed. Some of them went to sit at Economic and Organised Crime Office (EOCO), dragging themselves on the ground. This is because, they thought that someone who had done this disservice to this country has been arrested. We are all seated here and they want to tell me that we are not working hard against *galamsey*? That is what is being investigated. Whether they like it or not, we will take them on.

Mr Speaker, as for corruption, it is just by us. We have a very big swimming pool, and it is not only the swimming pool. If you talk about corruption, it is not only the swimming pool; there were bungalows there that were pulled down. About GHC58 million went down the drain. Nobody was found culpable. The then Government tried as much as they could to clear them to go scot-free.

We talk of development and we want to make sure that the grassroots actually get what is due of them. Yet, a contractor was taken to go and work on the Pwalugu Dam and he took not less than GHC11 million. They think that this Government is not doing its best? After the Government has made allocation of money, to ensure that the food that has been produced, would be bought and stored for the use of our students.

Mr Speaker, let us know that there is no way we are going to sit and watch the rice that has been properly produced by our people to go waste, when we know that the National Food Buffer Stock can buy and store for students to use. Instead of waiting to go and bring in rotten, expired and imported rice to re-bag and give to students, we would not do that. Because, money has been allocated in the Budget and for sure it is going to be made good use of.

Mr Speaker, as we continue, we should be conscious of the fact that in this country, the issue of roads came up very seriously. My own road is part of the Bolgatanga-Bawku-Pulmakom stretch. Immediately our Colleagues on the other Side came to power, within two

weeks, the project was stopped. I listened to someone say in this Chamber that, we want roads where there are human beings. Yes, indeed they would say that because this is what they have done. They do not know that the very onion that their wives or any other person who goes to the market to buy in Accra is carried on that road to Accra. So, they will stop such a contract in no time. They would now sit down and tell us that we are not doing what is expected of us.

Mr Speaker, I am so happy that when it comes to health, our Government, under H. E. John Dramani Mahama, is taking up not less than 10 of the Agenda 111 Projects. We want to let everyone in Ghana and for that matter our Colleagues seated opposite, to understand that resetting a country means that anything that would be done to benefit the Ghanaian and taxpayer, should be done. That is exactly what this Government is doing.

Otherwise, if we had been like them, when they came to power and decided to stop most contracts, we would not have done the Agenda 111 Projects. But we are quite aware that it is the money of the taxpayer and it is going to be to the benefit of every Ghanaian and so it is being done. We should not run away from issues and rather bring up issues.

Mr Speaker, I will not be able to finish without mentioning the Human Sexual Rights and Family Values Bill. Is it not interesting that we sat here, worked on the Bill, did everything possible, and eventually, when it was sent for the President then to append his signature,

he rejected it. Today, the same persons have the guts to tell us that we must sign it. We will. *Insha Allah*, we will sign it. H. E. John Dramani Mahama is ready to sign it. It will be signed because we are not going to dance to whatever they are doing or saying. We are going to do it and say it as expected of us.

Mr Speaker, if we come to the issue of projects and we suppose that this Government is not working hard to ensure that this country and for that matter, every Ghanaian benefits, I am not sure we would have been ensuring that the district assemblies are being given the funds to ensure that there are markets in basically every district. This is proper decentralisation because the Government is fully aware that many times, the prosperity of men, women, children, boys and girls end in the market. Let us even take Accra Central which is not too far.

2:27 p.m.

Mr Speaker, when we get there, we would realise that the market actually needs a lot of work. Even the *kayaye*, whom we were working hard to support, when they came, they decided to build hostels for them instead of training and supporting them. They find it difficult to walk in the markets when they go to carry goods for people. This is something that we must give a very big clap to H. E. John Dramani Mahama for.

Mr Speaker, we have always taunted and spoken about schools but what did

the previous Government do? There was no food for students in secondary schools and they were warned; headmasters and headteachers were warned that if they say there was no food, they would exit.

Mr Speaker, this Budget Statement and Economic Policy is resetting Ghana, and *inshallah* we would reset Ghana to the benefit of us all. Thank you very much, Mr Speaker—[*Hear! Hear!*].

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you, Hajia Laadi Ayamba. I will give the floor to my very good Friend, Hon Patrick Yaw Boamah—[*Hear! Hear!*—you have 15 minutes.

Mr Patrick Yaw Boamah (NPP—Okaikwei Central): Mr Speaker, thank you very much for giving me the opportunity to add my voice to the Statement being commented on by Hon Colleagues on the Floor.

Mr Speaker, for the first time in many years, the Budget Statement and Economic Policy of this country was read around 5:37 p.m. It is very important to make that point. Not during Mr Kwesi Botchwey, Mr Kwame Peprah, Mr Osafo Marfo, or Mr Baah Wiredu's time up to Dr Ato Forson who was the first.

Mr Speaker, there is a reason why your Budget Statement and Economic Policy must be read during prime time. When our Budget Statement and Economic Policy was read at 5:37 p.m. this year,

our major creditors were all asleep. Some of them were just waking up. The Chinese were asleep. The Australians were just waking up. Our European partners were at dinner. Ghanaians were rushing home to go and sleep after work. It tells and gives the reason for which the markets did not respond positively to our Budget Statement and Economic Policy this year.

Mr Speaker, why am I saying that? The Ghana cedi experienced a depreciation in value against the U.S. dollar on Friday, which was 14th November, 2025, a day after the Budget Statement and Economic Policy recorded an average buying rate of GH¢10.85 to the dollar and selling at around GH¢11.42. At the forex bureaus, the Ghana cedi was trading at GH¢12 to a dollar and purchasing at \$12.35 dollars to the Ghana cedi. It tells you how unresponsive our Budget Statement and Economic Policy was to the market and how investor-friendly it was not to the market.

Mr Speaker, I go to the meat of the Budget Statement and Economic Policy. Hajia Ayamba, this is the second Budget Statement and Economic Policy of His Excellency the President of the Republic of Ghana. You are not 10 months or 9 months into Government. If we read page 117 of this year's Budget Statement and Economic Policy and also page 71 of the 2025 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, it gives you all the key

policy indicators and programmes of the Government.

Mr Speaker, according to the Minister for Finance, revenue from oil is falling and I did not hear any specific policy measure to improve upon our oil revenues. As we speak, the Pecan oil block, which has Lukoil as a major stakeholder with 38 per cent, with Lukoil having to face sanctions from the United States of America, I expected the Minister to have given us a clear policy guideline on what the Government of Ghana was doing to shore up our oil revenues. And I read from the statement from the U.S. Department of Treasury Office of Foreign Assets Control (OFAC), that all assets of Lukoil ought to be taken care of or they should start with the process of winding up their assets by the end of this year. I know the officials of this Government are interested in the second gas processing plant, but this is a very important matter that the Government should have taken a closer look at. I know they are talking to some Americans on some plant in Oklahoma. Closely, we are monitoring to see the outcome of that.

Mr Speaker, in this year's Budget Statement and Economic Policy, I counted about 22 mentions of private sector in different paragraphs, but the private sector is not responding to the call of this Government. If we look at the

macroeconomic indicators that the Minister for Finance mentioned, inflation around 8 per cent, but the ones that the private sector has to look at to take the bold steps to invest and create the needed jobs in the country were very weak and low.

Mr Speaker, non-performing loans, according to the Bank of Ghana, is just around 23 per cent. This compares with most current banking industry NPLs of 4.2 per cent in Nigeria, 17.4 per cent for Kenya, and a ratio of 1 per cent for the South African banks. So, if the Government is refusing or has not taken any bold steps to pay contractors of monies owed them, how will they be able to go out and make the necessary borrowing, invest in the right sectors of the economy, and create the needed jobs that this Budget Statement and Economic Policy talks about?

Mr Speaker, if we look at the cover page of this year's Budget Statement and Economic Policy, we can see a clear photoshop of a certain express road that the Minister for Finance spoke about, that they were going to construct an express road to Kumasi.

Mr Speaker, what is the crime of the people of this country, especially those of us who plied our roads to our villages, from Accra to Paga and to Bawku? For eight years, from 2009 to 2016, not a

single kilometre of road was added by the National Democratic Congress (NDC) Administration — Yes. They are in government again, and instead of prioritising the completion of the dualisation of the Accra-Kumasi Road, they are telling us that they are going to construct an express road. From which funds? It is a complete misplaced priority. What Ghanaians want to see is the completion of the dualisation project that was started by the Akufo-Addo and Kufuor Administration. Then that can be looked at because the financial models do not help you. How are they going to construct this? Through a Public Private Partnership (PPP) arrangement? And how much are they going to charge road users? It is for them to take that decision.

Mr Speaker, let me share this data which I received from the National Road Safety Authority with the House. In 2025 only, deaths on the Accra-Kumasi highway were 525, 570 and 331 for the Eastern, Ashanti Greater Accra regions respectively. So, a reasonable government would take the completion of the dualisation programme as a priority, complete it, and save Ghanaian lives rather than taking another step of constructing an expressway, which I believe is not a priority for Ghanaians. It is very important that we look at that.

Mr Speaker, the Budget Statement and Economic Policy also made some

allocations to the agency responsible for the fight against *galamsey*. A whopping GH¢150 million has been allocated to them. I did some conversion and it came to about US\$13 million.

2:37 p.m.

It is a good step that we need to fight *galamsey*, but the monitoring mechanisms that ought to be in place, especially with the promise of the NDC Government, to come in and fight *galamsey*; I believe has not been met.

Mr Speaker, we are promised a complete state of emergency by the Government of the day. Various speakers at different political events made it a promise that they were going to ensure that the President issues a state of emergency. It is clear that the Government is not ready; it is clear that the Government is taking snail-paced steps in order to fight the *galamsey* menace.

Mr Speaker, the Catholic Bishop Conference has spoken—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The time should be stopped for Mr Patrick Boamah.

Yes, Hon Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, the NDC as a political party and Mr John Dramani Mahama as its candidate, never promised

a state of emergency. The manifesto is there. The manifesto captures the promises we made to Ghanaians, and there are video clips of every rally and every statement of the candidate Mr John Dramani Mahama, and he never promised a state of emergency.

So, I believe the Hon Member can retract that and we can continue; even though, I have no problem if the Hon Member says that an express way to Kumasi is unnecessary, and that the people of Kumasi do not deserve an express way. *[Uproar]* I think that the state of emergency was never promised. There was never a commitment of Mr John Dramani Mahama and the NDC.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Mr Patrick Boamah, did you say some experts proposed a declaration of state of emergency, or you said that the NDC promised a state of emergency?

Mr Boamah: I said the NDC promised a state of emergency, and I insist on that. Mr Speaker, it is on record.

Mr Speaker, the Hon Majority Leader has become the Chief Interjector of Debates. It is within his right, but the people of the Ashanti Region, Eastern Region, Upper East region, Upper West Region, Bono Region, Bono East and Ahafo Regions deserve the completion of the Accra-Kumasi-Techiman dualisation project. It is a priority that the Government must take into consideration—*[Interruption]*.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Accra-Kumasi-Techiman?

Mr Boamah: Yes, because you cannot go to Techiman—unless you want to go through Atebubu and Nkoranza, through Mampong, that is what I was talking about. So, we need that road. The country needs it. Mr Ayariga needs it, the people of Bawku need it; and Hajia Laadi needs it to Pusiga, and it is one of the most important routes in this country.

Mr Speaker, on Appendix 3 of this year's Budget, the Bank of Ghana is promising, again, zero financing of our Budget; we saw that in 2025, and we are seeing that again in 2026. The question that I want to ask the Bank of Ghana is that, who is funding the Gold Reserve Programme? How much gold has been purchased? How much has been sold? At what rates, and at what price? What has been the impact of this Gold Reserve Programme on the books of Bank of Ghana? Has it resulted in some losses? These are questions that the Bank of Ghana will have to come here to answer in due course.

Mr Speaker, the Bank of Ghana is financing activities under the Gold Reserve Programme, because I filed a Right to Information (RTI) question, to the Ministry of Finance, when I saw that the Ministry had not released a single cedi to the GoldBod. I got a response from the Ministry of Finance, and they

confirmed, in a letter signed by the Chief Director of the Ministry, that indeed, the Ministry has not made a single allocation to the GoldBod. So, where is the GoldBod getting its funds from? If the Bank of Ghana is saying they would to continue with zero financing, how are they being funded? So, Mr Speaker, these are important matters that we will be looking at.

Mr Speaker, we are not against a programme to stabilise the currency, but the transparency that it requires, as the representatives of the people, we need to know so that no laundered funds are brought into the country to be used for some illicit activity. I am not impugning that.

Mr Speaker, thus far, I would like to commend the maker of the Statement, the Minister of Finance, for presenting the Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Republic of Ghana on behalf of the President. And I ask that during the Estimates and debates that will ensue, we will bring to the fore that if a vote is taken around the Cabinet table, I do not think the Minister for Finance will score 30 per cent, because he has failed to make budgetary allocations to the Ministries; and they know it. He will not score 30 per cent, or 10 per cent, around the table. Alhaji Suhuyini, is aware—*[Laughter]*.

This is my plea to the Hon Minister, to make the Government function, and release adequate resources for the good

people of this country to enjoy its benefits.

I thank you very much, Mr Speaker.
[Hear! Hear!]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I will now give the floor to Mr Thomas Ampem, you have 15 minutes.

Mr Thomas Nyarko Ampem (NDC — Asuogyaman): Mr Speaker, today I have listened to Mr Patrick Boamah, Mr Nitiwul, the former Defence Minister, and others, and over the last three days or so, we have had the opportunity to listen to many of them, take their turn to debate the Budget Statement and Economic Policy that was presented by my boss, Dr Ato Forson, which has received an overwhelming endorsement by Ghanaians.

In fact, many people have made reference to the survey that indicated that about 82 per cent of respondents have given approval to this Budget. They may choose to believe it or not, that is up to them, whether they decide to take public opinion or not—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Kyei Asamoah, I can hear you.

Mr Ampem: Or just depend on your own ideas, that is up to you.

Mr Speaker, one thing is clear today, that the debate as to who are better managers of the economy of Ghana has been settled. If you know, you know. The record is so clear. Inflation that we inherited at 23.8 per cent, today has

reduced significantly to 8 per cent, and nobody has disputed that throughout the debate. Public debt, as we inherited, GH¢726 billion in December, has reduced significantly to GH¢630 billion. Primary balance has moved from a deficit of 3.5 per cent to a surplus of 1.6 per cent, something they could never imagine that was possible under them.

Mr Speaker, our reserves also speak volumes. In 2016, when we were handing over to the NPP, our reserves were GH¢6.2 billion. Eight years after, in 2024, when they were handing over back to us, they had increased their reserves to GH¢9 billion; they added GH¢2.8 billion. For 10 months, from January this year to date, we have increased the reserves to GH¢11.4 billion. [*Hear! Hear!*]

2:47 p.m.

Mr Speaker, it took them eight good years to increase our reserves by GH¢2.8 billion. That is 96 months to increase our reserves by US\$2.8 billion. It has taken President Mahama and his Minister for Finance, Dr Ato Forson, and the Governor of the Bank of Ghana to 10 months, only 10 months, to increase our reserves by US\$2.4 billion. Would they compare themselves to us?

Mr Speaker, I listened to the immediate past Minister for Finance yesterday, and he made certain statements. He referred to this wonderful Budget as a “jobless Budget”. A Budget that allocates GH¢500 million to oil palm plantation, would you call that a jobless budget? A Budget that allocates

GH¢30 billion to Big Push for infrastructure, is that a jobless budget? A Budget that allocates GH¢828 million to construct 1,000 kilometres of agri-sector roads, is that a jobless budget? A Budget that allocates GH¢100 million for aquaculture development, would you call that a jobless budget? [**Some Hon Members:** No!] A Budget that seeks to restructure VAT, to give back money to businesses, for them to increase their profit, to expand and employ more, is that a jobless budget? [**Some Hon Members:** No!]

Mr Speaker, the former Minister for Finance, Dr Mohammed Amin Adam, made a statement that I want to quote. He says, “I am saying that out of the 45 treasury auctions conducted since January, 25 of them failed”.

I do not know what the former Minister for Finance is calling failure here, because since the beginning of this year, we have made a deliberate decision to reject bids. In fact, to date, we have rejected a total of GH¢71 billion in bids. Our approach is simple. Instead of Government borrowing and crowding out the private businesses, we said no, we will not take it. Give the money to the private sector. The latest figures in September this year shows that private sector credit increased by GH¢12.7 billion compared to that of September 2024. However, public sector credit contracted by GH¢3 billion in the same year. This is showing Government's deliberate policy of directing credit to the private sector. That is the difference between us and them. As a result of this,

average lending rate to the private sector has reduced from 30 per cent in January, 2025 to 22.7 per cent as I speak. Government has decided that we will not take the money, so the banks have no option but to lend to the private sector for the private sector to grow and create more jobs for us.

Mr Speaker, one issue that our opponents have been talking about since the beginning of this debate is to question the growth rate that we indicated in the Budget at 4.8 per cent. I take their criticisms as an encouragement for us to do more for Ghana. That is how I want to interpret their criticisms. But if you look at it, half-year growth under them in 2024 was 5.1 per cent. The same period for us, we have grown this economy by 6.3 per cent. So, I want to tell them that by the end of the year, we will exceed our target. Our approach is different from theirs. We promise less and deliver more. They blow their horns; they promise and walk all over and do little. That is the difference between us.

Mr Speaker, I listened to Hon Patrick Yaw Boamah who just stepped out. He talked about the time the Budget was presented. It was not our decision at the Ministry of Finance to come and present the Budget that late. It was a deliberate delay on their part that caused the Budget to be presented late. I was personally worried that because the Budget was being presented late, it would not get the traction that it needed. But guess what? Ghanaians have really shown that they believe in H. E. President Mahama. They believe in the policies of Dr Cassiel Ato Forson.

Mr Speaker, back to the statement made by the former Minister for Finance, in fact, I was shocked to hear Dr Amin Adam complain that we are not borrowing more and auctions are not—Is it that for them success is about borrowing? Clearly, they borrowed and celebrated by throwing a *kenkey* party. We do not see borrowing as an achievement. For us, an achievement is managing less to do more for Ghanaians—[*Hear! Hear!*]—In fact, if quoting the Bible had not been made unpopular by somebody, I would have supported this with a Bible story that talks about feeding thousands of men with five loaves of bread and two pieces of fish, but I do not want to go there. So, we want to manage this economy with the little resources. And that is why we are doing more, even at a time that we do not have access to the international bond market; that is what is happening today to our economy.

Mr Speaker, I saw the former Minister for Defence on his feet and he spoke about retooling of the Military. I wanted to be sure whether he was against the retooling of the Military, but he chose his words and said that he is not against it and I am happy that he is not against it. But the information I am getting from the Military, the sector he headed for eight years, is that only one of the three aircrafts he spoke about is functional as we speak; only one is flying. [**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** You let it rot.] Recently, they said the aircrafts were not fit for purpose, and they justified why the President should rent jets and bath in the air. They did that here. Today, because

their sitting position has changed, they are singing from a different hymn book.

Mr Speaker, the Hon Majority Leader indicated that they will get the details, the specifications for all this equipment that we are buying for the Military. We will interrogate them here, and I will tell them that the cost of one aircraft will be far less than the amount they spend for President Akufo-Addo to rent luxurious aircrafts and fly around.

Mr Speaker, we in this Government are trying very hard to fix the many messes that we inherited from our predecessors. If we go to the Energy sector, we inherited an Independent Power Producers (IPP) debt of US\$1.6 billion. As at the end of the second quarter of this year, the debt stood at US\$1.4 billion. It has taken the combined efforts of my boss Dr Ato Forson and Mr John Abdulai Jinapor to renegotiate this debt with the IPPs, and the renegotiation has saved us US\$252 million. As I speak, the new renegotiated figure of US\$1.19 billion has been structured to be paid over a period of five years. In this year, 2025, we have programmed to pay US\$397 million. We are almost done with the payment of this amount. Next year, 2026, we have programmed to pay US\$282 million. Dr Ato Forson says that we even want to front load this amount and pay the amount earmarked for next year, this year, so that we can free fiscal space for other things next year.

2:57 p.m.

Mr Speaker, the Electricity Company of Ghana (ECG), today, is on course. We are no longer building arrears. If we look at the trend, the energy sector poses a

serious risk to our Budget. Last year, for the energy sector shortfall alone, we programmed GH¢29 billion. Because of the prudent management by this Government, we will spend far less than that. Because we have been able to increase gas production, which is substituting for the expensive fuel in powering our plants.

If we look at the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, because of this prudence, we are allocating only GH¢15 billion for the energy sector shortfall. A reduction from 29 to 15. We are working towards a time when the amount will be reduced significantly.

Mr Speaker, these are the things that are happening in this country, and everybody is applauding President Mahama and the Minister for Finance.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Time keepers, stop the time for the Deputy Minister for Finance. Yes, Minority Leader.

Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, I have followed the submissions of our Colleague, the Deputy Minister for Finance. He had no submissions on his own, save that he kept referring to submissions made by this Side. But he made a very fundamental submission that is in error. He contended, through his submissions, that there is some prudence and efficiency at the Electricity Company of Ghana (ECG).

Mr Speaker, what he failed to tell this House is that, this year alone, utility tariffs have gone up by over 18 per cent. All the tariffs that have gone up—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, you will have your turn to debate.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: No, Mr Speaker, it is a point of order.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: If he said something that you think is not true, then you can interrupt.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, I am on a point of order.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, what is your point of order?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, my point of order is grounded on the fact that he is misleading the House by presenting some facts that do not support the reality. What he said was that at ECG, they are getting more revenue now because of prudence to enable them pay their debts.

Mr Speaker, that is not correct and it is misleading.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, so state a correct position.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, it is misleading because the revenue increase is a result of the 18 per

cent tariff adjustment we have seen thus far.

Two, on the issue of their ability to pay more to the Independent Power Producers (IPPs), it is a result of the one Ghana cedi levy they have imposed at the pumps. They came here and said that because the energy sector was accumulating debts, they needed to impose the energy sector levy—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, Minority Leader, what is your point of order? Is it the case that the revenue is increasing, or not?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, thank you for patiently enquiring. He contended that the revenue increase at ECG is a result of prudent management. My rebuttal in terms of the misleading fact is that the revenue increase is a result of the 18 per cent tariff adjustment. It is not because of prudent management.

Mr Speaker, two, the IPPs that are getting more funds to pay them are as a result of the one Ghana cedi per litre of petroleum. It is as a result of that *dumsor* levy because in their submissions before the House, when they brought the levy, their argument was that the energy sector was accumulating debts. Therefore, they needed to impose this one Ghana cedi per litre. So, if they say there is prudent management—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, with all due respect,

this does not qualify within our rules as point of order. That is your opinion, and he is also entitled to his opinion. If you have the opportunity to debate, you may do so.

I do not consider this to be misleading the House, which may probably form a subject matter of privileges by the rules. I recognise Hon Ayariga.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Very well, if that is your pleasure.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, when the Minority Leader rose and caught your eye, you asked him, and he said he was rising on a point of order. And you asked specifically which point of order. Then he said the Hon Deputy Minister is misleading the House.

So, Mr Speaker, I want him to show me specifically which provisions of our Standing Orders say that he can rise on a point of order claiming that a Member is misleading the House.

Mr Speaker, let me read Order 122 from beginning to end. Because all our viewers are here, the televisions are on. Order 122 says:

“(1) Debate may be interrupted

(a) by a point of order being raised;

(b) by a matter of privilege suddenly arising;

(c) by a point of information, elucidation or clarification;

(d) by attention being called to the absence of a quorum;

(e) by attention being called to the presence of a stranger in the House; or

(f) upon a point of procedure”

There is nothing about misleading the House. These are the grounds for raising, interrupting a debate. And if one wants to further raise a point of order, one must also go to the content of the speech, that is, Order 123, and show that the speech being made by the person on whom one is raising a point of order violates the provisions of Order 123 on the content of a speech. Order 123 also says:

“(1) A Member or a person entitled to participate in a debate shall not make reference to any matter on which judicial decision is pending in such a way as may, in the opinion of the person presiding, prejudice the interest of parties to the action.”

So, one cannot comment on a judicial decision pending, but a point of order can be raised.

“(2) A Member shall not

(a) use offensive, abusive, insulting, blasphemous or unbecoming words on a Member or any other person; or

(b)impute improper motives, or impugn the integrity of a Member or any other person.”

So those are the grounds on which one can say that a Member is out of order because the content of his speeches violates these Orders.

“(5) A Member shall not raise any specific Question upon which the House has come to a conclusion during the current session, except on a substantive Motion for rescission.

(6) The speech of a Member shall be relevant to the subject matter under discussion”

These are the matters that the content of speech allows one to raise a point of order. I have heard people now and again rise and say the Member is misleading the House. No specific provision grounds one to raise a point of order simply by saying that a Member is misleading the House.

So, the Hon Minority Leader should show us specifically which provision of our Standing Orders he is standing on to interrupt debate?

3:07 p.m.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Yes, a very good exercise indeed. I earlier saw the Hon Majority Leader rise on his feet to interrupt Mr Patrick Boamah. The Hon Member who leads this House did not cite any Order. I heard him; I was watching him. In fact, his attempt excited my entry into this Chamber. He said that

the NDC did not state in their Manifesto that they were going to impose a state of emergency in this *galamsey* matter. He did not consider it a rebuttal which will be contained in his own submissions. But he got up to say that the Hon Member must be interrupted. Anyway, I am tempted to say that he comes seeking equity without doing equity. But since he has invited me on procedure, I will face him squarely.

Mr Speaker, the Hon Majority Leader is known for convenience. Even when he himself had argued that when a matter is pending before court, this House should stay its hands, he is the same person to quickly say that even when a matter is pending before court, the House is not estopped. This is Mr Ayariga for you.

Some Hon Members: No principles!

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: That is Ayariga, the convenience principle. He has introduced a convenience principle.

Mr Speaker, if he is saying that he is reading Order 122, there is no— Can the Majority Leader keep quiet and gently listen because that was what I did. That is the rule. You must keep quiet and listen.

Mr Speaker, Order 122 upon which I mounted my argument of point of order is very clear. At what point do you interrupt debates? The content of the speech is misleading. If a Member argues that ECG has had increasing revenue as

a result of prudence, what is the meaning of prudence? Meaning that previously, the management of funds led to some waste. However, under this new management, they have taken some steps. Therefore, those steps have led to an increase in revenue. Mr Speaker, first of all, when they were in opposition, they criticised the Hubtel software machinery that has been put in place. They came, and it is the same Hubtel system that is there.

Secondly, we are telling them that the increase in revenue is as a result of the 18 per cent tariff adjustment. That is one.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, I earlier—

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, when the Majority leader was on his feet, you never asked him a question. This is becoming one too many. I will not accept this. [*Uproar*]

You allowed him to speak. When it gets to us, then you start asking questions. Why did you not interrupt him? Mr Speaker, do not do this.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Which Question did I ask you?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, do not do this. Whenever they are on their feet, Mr Speaker does not talk to them.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Minority Leader, which question did I ask you?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, you never interrupted him—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Which question did I ask you?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, you never interrupted him. When he was on his feet, we were all quiet listening to him.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, which question did I ask you?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, when he was on his feet, not a word came from you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, you can have a disagreement with what he, the Deputy Minister for Finance, is saying. You will have the opportunity to debate. You have indicated that if the revenue was increased, it was because they increased the tariff. If, in his opinion, that is prudent, that he is entitled to. That cannot amount to misleading the House.

Hon Minority Leader, you will have the opportunity to disagree with him. But your disagreement with what he is saying will not amount to a point of order within the meaning of the rules.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, you have made a good call. Earlier, you ruled, and upon ruling, I resumed my seat. However, you granted the space for the Hon Majority Leader to come in to now ask me a specific question. He asked me a question on procedure. You allowed him to flow until he finished—*[Interruption]*—Mr Speaker, you can hear him, you see.

Mr Speaker, you gave me the opportunity to respond to him because I had yielded to your ruling. But because you gave him the opportunity to ask me a direct question on Order 122 and 123, it was therefore important to come back to explain to him the mainstay of my argument. So, if Mr Speaker is keeping to his ruling, I will yield because, if you rule, that is the order.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, that is exactly what I am trying to do.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Again, the rule on fairness also requires that both Sides must be treated fairly. If you have ruled on my matter, then what was the basis for the Majority Leader coming back as if he was the presiding officer? He came back reading the same rules again and going on to say that I should answer. These were his words, and you asked that the Hon Minority Leader respond. That is why I was responding.

Mr Speaker, if this is your ruling, so be it. I take it. Thank you so much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Thank you. Yes, Hon Deputy Minister, you may conclude.

Mr Ampem: Mr Speaker, in Akan, when a leader leads an army to war and he returns victorious, he is given “*Osahene*”. But when the leader goes to war with a contingent of 137 and returns with only 78, he is referred to as “*Osaakoa*”. *[Laughter]*

Mr Speaker, I was on the point that ECG—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: What is the meaning?

Mr Ampem: A war slave.

Mr Speaker, I was making the point that the energy sector is now being prudently managed. Coincidentally, the Minister for Energy and Green Transition has just walked in. The Hon Minority Leader was questioning the prudence that I was talking about. The prudence is where ECG today is not procuring things that they do not need.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, your time is up.

I will proceed to give the floor to Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko. You have 10 minutes.

Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko (NPP — Effia): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to comment on the Budget Statement and Economic Policy read by the Minister for Finance regarding the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy of Government.

Mr Speaker, let me commence by speaking to one or two of the issues raised by the Deputy Minister for Finance. Unfortunately, the Hon Deputy Minister for Finance for the past 15 minutes never commented on the Budget that he supported in presenting to the House. He only came in to comment on remarks that have been passed by the Minority, to which he thinks he disagreed. That tells us as a House that the Budget that was presented by the Minister for Finance is not fit for purpose, and lacks substance.

Mr Speaker, the 2026 Budget is a run-off to the 2025 Budget. So, the 2025 Budget will entitle us to interrogate and find out what the issues were that were promised in 2025, and what had been the Government's performance in 2025 before we can even have something to comment on the 2026 Budget. As the Minister for Finance said, why would one say that an allocation for GH¢30 billion Big Push is a bad Budget? Why would one say GH¢825 million to construct 1,000 kilometres of agriculture roads is a bad Budget?

3:17 p.m.

Why would they say GH¢825 million to construct 1,000 kilometres of agriculture roads is a bad budget? Why would they say GH¢100 million for aquaculture is a bad budget? Allocation is not release. So, it is the same way they allocated GH¢50 million for the Women's Development Bank, but it never came to pass. The GH¢50 million allocation for coders never came to pass. It is for the same reason that we cannot

trust the allocations in the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy. If wishes were horses, beggars would ride.

Mr Speaker, let us go into the 2025 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, as was presented and is being looked at. On page 151, Appendix 1C, it talks about the general growth performance of Government between 2025 and 2026.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: That is the 2025 Budget Statement and Economic Policy.

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: No, 2026. I am referencing the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: But you said 2025, that is why I am interjecting.

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: No, 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy.

Mr Speaker, the theme of the Budget Statement and Economic Policy is "Resetting for Growth, Jobs and Economic Transformation", yet, when we look at it, there is very little that speaks on promoting growth, jobs and bringing transformation. I am saying this in the context of industry. This is because the employment situation in this country is hinged on how well government is resourcing industry and the service sector for growth.

On page 151 under "Industry", the industry in 2024 grew by 7.1 per cent, however, in 2025, it grew by 3.6 per cent, a whopping decline of 100 per cent in

terms of growth in the industry. If we go under “Industry”, the major areas that propelled growth is manufacturing and construction. If we go to manufacturing, the industry grew by 3.9 per cent in 2024, and it is just growing, according to Government, at 4.0 per cent, which is flat. When we go to construction, in 2024, it grew by 9.6 per cent in 2024, but in 2025, it grew by 2.9 per cent. These are the areas that the Ghanaian people are seeking for employment. These are the areas that affect the growth and development of the youth, but they are dealing with all the macroeconomic indicators. Interest rates are falling and the cedi is appreciating, but where is it hitting the pockets of the unemployed youth in this country?

Mr Speaker, we go to service industry. The Minister said service industry is growing by 6.4 per cent in 2025 as against 5.4 per cent. But we have to check the detail of the service industry. When we take “Trade: Repair of Vehicles, Household Goods” is where the Abossey Okai people want to see growth, so that they can employ people. In 2024, it grew by 3.6 per cent, but 2025 is growing by 3.1 per cent which is a decline.

Hotels and restaurants, where Ghanaian industries are looking at creating jobs, in 2024, grew by 4.8 per cent. In 2025, it is growing by 3.5 per cent, a decline in growth. Mr Speaker, when we go to transport and storage, in 2024 it was 5.8 per cent, but in 2025 it is 3.5 per cent. The entire areas of growth that will propel employment for the

youth are all on a decline. So, what is the Government telling us when it comes to employment? The Government is saying that it is going to employ over 800,000 people, however, in 2025, they could not tell Ghanaians the number of jobs that they have created.

Mr Speaker, let me move into the revenue situation. If we check from the Government, revenue has fallen from GH¢189 billion to GH¢186 billion. Indirect tax has also fallen. So, the Government does not even have the revenue to grow this economy. In 2026, the Government is still projecting higher revenue, yet, it has not put in place strategies to collect revenue to grow the economy. Mr Speaker, the Government reduced tax refund from 6 per cent to 4 per cent, yet, the refund for the year 2025 and 2026, under page 154, are all on a decline. So, there is very little that gives hope to employment for the youth of this country.

Mr Speaker, on the VAT reform that the Minister talked about, consolidating VAT to 20 per cent from 21.9 per cent, the real estate sector is supposed to be charged a whopping 20 per cent of tax out of 5 per cent that they were paying under real estate. So, housing deficit is going to increase in this country, and real estate is going to collapse under this Government.

Mr Speaker, let me move on to the energy sector, while my good Brother Hon John Abdulai Jinapor is here. Page 118, paragraph 900 of the Budget

Statement and Economic Policy says that'

"Ghana's oil production has witnessed consistent decline over the years, falling from 71.4 million barrels in 2019 to an estimated 36 million barrels in 2025, almost 50 per cent decline."

That is almost 50 million decline. That is our Budget talking to us. Yet, there is no strategic direction in improving or increasing our petroleum sector. Yesterday, the Minister brought out Springfield, that they are taking away indigenous Ghanaian companies from the energy sector upstream. I am asking the Minister that when did they go into taking the foreign entities, that they are now coming to Ghanaian companies?

In conclusion, Mr Speaker, I believe that the 2026 Budget does not provide hope for the teeming youth of this country. My Colleagues on the other Side should tell me how many people they have employed in their constituencies in the year 2025? They should tell me. All of them are chasing jobs but they cannot find them. Even when they recruiting into the Military, over 80,000 applied and then six had to perish because of their mismanagement and the way the recruitment in security sector is done.

Mr Speaker, I am saying that the youth want credible opportunities for job creation. It is not just about the macroeconomic indicators. It is about strategic thinking in promoting economic activities. The productive sectors of this economy have not been

touched. Government only promises with allocation but they do not give releases. Ministries, Departments and Agencies (MDAs) have not received what they require, even to grow their ministries. That is why all of us sitting in this Chamber can talk about the macro indices, but we are looking at ourselves miserably. Communities are poor, the economy is looking good macroeconomically, but our pockets are dry. The Minister has to check that. I thank you for the opportunity. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, permit me to acknowledge the presence of Students of Food Science and Technology from the Northern Region, specifically Sagnarigu. They are led by Samuel Sam, lecturer, and they are from Sagnarigu Municipality. They are 73 in number.

We also have University of Professional Studies (UPSA), Accra, led by Richard Yao Fiajoe, group leader. They are from Madina and they are 58 in number.

Hon Members, on your behalf, I welcome all of them. May you have a fruitful stay.

[Students of Food Science and Technology were acknowledged]

[Students of University of Professional Studies (UPSA), Accra were acknowledged]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, at Conclave, we agreed to take a 30-minute break, and this is the point to take the 30-minute break. My time is 3:26 p.m., so, we are coming back exactly at 4 o'clock.

3:26 p.m. — *Sitting suspended.*

4.49 p.m. — *Sitting resumed.*

[THE SPEAKER, RT HON ALBAN SUMANA KINGSFORD BAGBIN, IN THE CHAIR]

The Speaker: Majority Leader, any guidance?

Mr Ayariga: Thank you, Mr Speaker. There is some understanding that before we resume commentary on the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, we will take a very short Statement on the 65th anniversary of the greatest secondary school. It will be a very short one. The anniversary is this Saturday, and so we are engaged with the First Deputy Speaker, and he had agreed that upon resumption, we will take that Statement, and then get back to the commentary on the Budget.

The Speaker: Yes, Minority Leader?

Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, the Majority Leader wants us to take a Statement to celebrate the 65th Anniversary of the school he attended.

Mr Speaker, that should not be a problem. It is safe that these matters are

discussed by all parties in the scheme of affairs. I have been informed by my Colleagues in Leadership that the only matter that came up was Rev Helen Adjoa Ntoso's Statement to celebrate World Children's Day. That is what they know.

But, Mr Speaker, he is the Leader of the House; our *primus*. If on an occasion like this, he wants us to say a word or two to honour the school that has made him who he is today, it is something that this Side of the House will not oppose. Therefore, the prayer as prayed be granted, except that soon thereafter, we may have to take Rev Helen Adjoa Ntoso's Statement. Mr Speaker, I am advised that soon thereafter, we will resume the debate which is now christened as comment. We will go back to it, and then he will decide his pleasure on this World Children's Day Statement.

The Speaker: Hon Members, from the brief I have, it is the Statement by the Rev Helen Adjoa Ntoso, the Member of Parliament for Krachi West, to celebrate the World Children's Day. That should be on now. Only the Majority Leader has requested that a Statement be made about his—I do not know what it is; his senior high or secondary school, but what they gave me here is only about Rev Helen Adjoa Ntoso. So, let us take that one before we come to yours. First things first, please. I have not even seen the Statement they will make on the school.

STATEMENTS

World Children's Day

Rev Helen Adjoa Ntoso (NDC — Krachi West): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for giving me the opportunity to make this Statement in commemoration of this year's World Children's Day. Mr Speaker, World Children's Day is not just another date on our calendar. It is a global day set aside to emphasise the importance of promoting children's rights and welfare in accordance with the "Convention of the Rights of the Child", which underscores the global commitment to protecting children's rights.

Mr Speaker, the treaty on the "Convention of the Rights of the Child" came into force on 2nd September, 1990 and remains one of the most widely ratified human rights treaty in the world. The theme for this year's World Children's Day is "My Day, My Rights", focusing on amplifying children's voices and ensuring that their rights are recognised and upheld. The theme reminds us that children are not only passive objects of care and policy, but active holders of rights, voices, dreams, and ideas.

Too often, Mr Speaker, children speak but they are not heard. They express concerns but are not taken seriously often. Yet, they are the truest mirrors of our society's successes and failures. As leaders, parents, guardians, and

stakeholders, it is imperative that we commit ourselves anew to creating a world where every child is safe, educated, healthy, valued, and given the opportunity to reach their full potential.

Mr Speaker, to listen to children means to invite them into conversations concerning their lives, be it education, safety, behavioural change, well-being, or the aspirations for the future. It calls for the creation of an environment where children are respected and protected and their rights supported in practice, not in words.

As a nation, we have the responsibility to give our children safe homes and communities in which to grow without any form of anxiety. Our schools need to remain valued as places that nurture talents and encourage our children's dreams. We must give a fair chance to every child, particularly the most vulnerable, those with special needs, those living in disadvantaged rural and urban communities and those children living in poverty which is not by their making.

Mr Speaker, the World Children's Day requires us to recommit ourselves to building a Ghana where no child is left behind. It calls on us to move beyond just symbolic gestures and take real and sustained action through consolidating child protection systems, investing in quality education, ensuring access to healthcare, ending harmful practices, and amplifying the voices of children in national decision-making.

I associate myself with the ideas of Mahatma Gandhi, who posited that “The greatness of any nation is measured not by its wealth or power but by how well it protects its children.” Let us rise to this responsibility with compassion, courage and undeterred dedication.

4:59 p.m.

Let us listen to our children, not just today, but every day, and work continually to safeguard their rights, their well-being and their future. It is indeed a clarion call to action for all of us to help amplify the voices of our children and stand up for the rights of every child.

Mr Speaker, may we on this day join voices around the world to emphasise the importance of promoting children’s rights and welfare in accordance with the Convention on the Rights of the Child, which underlies the global commitment to protecting children’s rights.

Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity. [*Hear! Hear!*]

The Speaker: Comments. How many minutes per person? Two minutes? Very well.

Yes, Hon Joseph Kwame Kumah?

Mr Joseph Kwame Kumah (NDC — Kintampo North): Thank you, Mr Speaker for giving me the opportunity to have a comment on the Statement made by Rev Ntoso.

The right of children is a very laudable one of which we should continue to remind ourselves. While we are looking at the rights of children, we want to appeal to parents to give listening ears to their children. It is very interesting the sort of things that come up when one interacts well with their children. One will be a happy father. So, parents should actually make time to have conversation with their children despite the challenges of the world. I know most parents in the cities and in the rural areas who wake up early and go to their farms and others to the market centres and do not easily make time for their children. But if we make time for our children, the interesting things that they tell us, the suggestions they make to us as parents, one will tend to like them and in the long run, they will fit in a society that we all deserve and like to see.

Much as we are talking of their rights, children also have responsibility. Children who are listening should know that apart from their rights, they have responsibility to listen to their parents and to also do their homework. They have a responsibility to continue to attend school, to do the right things in school so that their parents will also love them and in the end, will get a better world for all of us.

Mr Speaker, to this, I am grateful for the opportunity.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Korkor Asante? You have two minutes.

Mrs Korkor Laurette Asante (NPP — Atiwa West): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to the Statement. I commend my senior Colleague for the Statement that she made.

Mr Speaker, the strength of a nation lies in how it guides and nurtures its youth. So today, we have to raise the awareness of protecting children, and also, it is not just a celebration of children, but it is also a reminder of our responsibilities as adults towards protecting the children's rights, protecting them from violence, protecting them from paedophilia and protecting them from incest. We also have to celebrate the creativity, the enthusiasm and the limitless potential in terms of the future of our children because they are the future of this country.

Mr Speaker, this is a chance to amplify the voices of children and allow them to express their concerns and share their ideas and their dreams. We should not suppress or stifle the children's thoughts. We should be open to them and their concerns and should not just say that they are too young, because it is from what they say that we get to know their needs and how they will be shaping the future. What we can also do is to gather their thoughts in terms of their views and place them in a role, for instance, if they were members of Parliament or presidents for a day, what political priorities would they like to see? What would they like to do if they were presidents for a day? What would they

like to see in their communities if they were members of Parliament for a day?

Mr Speaker, you would be very surprised what the children will say because that will actually shape what our political priorities should be. It will also instil in the children that one day, they could also become member of Parliament or presidents because they will definitely be in those roles in the future.

Mr Speaker, today is a day that reminds us that we must make the world a safer place for the children, protect them and not stifle their creativity and their enthusiasm. It also reminds us of our responsibilities towards children.

Thank you, Mr Speaker for the opportunity.

The Speaker: Thank you so much. We move on the next Statement which stands in the name of the Hon Member for Tamale North, Alhaji Suhuyini Alhassan, Statement on the 65th Anniversary of Ghana Secondary School, Tamale.

The 65th Anniversary of Ghana Secondary School, Tamale

Alhaji Suhuyini Sayibu Alhassan (NDC — Tamale North): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to make this Statement to mark the 65th Anniversary of Ghana Secondary School (GHANASCO), Tamale.

Mr Speaker, it is with immense pride and a deep sense of nostalgia that I rise on behalf of the entire GHANASCO community, past and present students, dedicated staff, supportive parents and the esteemed board of governors, to celebrate a significant milestone, the 65th Anniversary of Ghana Secondary School, Tamale, fondly known as GHANASCO.

In the context of Ghana's educational history, GHANASCO's establishment was a significant step by Osagyefo Dr Kwame Nkrumah in expanding quality secondary education to the northern parts of the country. For decades, it has been an engine of social mobility and an intellectual hub, producing the skilled manpower that drives our agriculture, civil service, health and education sectors.

Mr Speaker, distinguished individuals such as one of Ghana's most celebrated bankers and majestic traditional ruler, Mr Alhassan Andani (Pushigu Lana); the Hon Majority Leader of this august House and Member of Parliament for Bawku Central, Mr Mahama Ayariga; the former youngest Pro-Vice Chancellor of any university in Ghana, Professor Felix Kofi Abagaale; the highly regarded paediatrician, Professor Alhassan Abdul-Mumin; Abedi Ayew Pele, three-time African Footballer of the Year, and his brother, Kwame Ayew Pele; our celebrated Minister for Energy, John Abdulai Jinapor; and of course H. E. John Dramani Mahama, and his ever supportive and loving wife, the First Lady of the Republic of Ghana, Mrs Lordina Mahama; and of course my

humble self, all consider this great institution more than just a school. It was a furnace that forged our character, a nursery that nurtured our talent, and it remains a beacon of hope and opportunity for generations of young Ghanaians.

Indeed, Mr Speaker, in this Chamber today, GHANASCO has the highest number of old students who are Members of Parliament in this country: Prof Hamza of Kumbungu, Hon Zuwera Ibrahimah of Salaga South, Hon Fathahiya Abdul-Aziz of Savelugu, Prof Alidu Seidu of Tamale Central, Hon Dan Latif of Ablekuma Central, Hon Solomon Kuyon of Krachi-Nchiumuru, Hon Alhassan Tampuli Sulemana of Gushegu, Hon Alhassan Umar of Zabzugu and others.

For 65 years, GHANASCO has been a pillar of academic excellence and character formation in northern Ghana. Its motto, "*Dania Suma Ni Suglo*" has guided countless alumni to become leaders in every sector of our national life.

In 1974, GHANASCO became the first school in Ghana and Africa to launch a rocket, a landmark achievement that demonstrated the practical application of science education.

5:09 p.m.

This event remains a key part of the school's history, and the rocket is featured on the school crest, etched on every uniform to remind students of their limitless capabilities.

This 65th Anniversary is a testament to the resilience of its staff, the dedication of its students, and the enduring support of its community. As we look to the future, the role of schools like GHANASCO is more critical than ever. Investing in them is an investment in national cohesion and sustainable development. Therefore, as we celebrate this 65-year journey, let us pledge to equip GHANASCO with the modern tools and infrastructure it needs to thrive in the 21st century.

This weekend, Mr Speaker, when we gather on the school compound, His Excellency the President, will commission an ultra-modern science laboratory and cut sod for the construction of an astroturf and other infrastructure facilities. I congratulate GHANASCO and wish it greater heights in the years to come. I also call on alumni, both home and abroad, to continue supporting their alma mater. Let us acknowledge the tireless efforts of the current teaching and non-teaching staff who carried the torch forward.

And when one sees the beautiful buildings in GHANASCO that are painted for this anniversary, thank the Majority Leader of this House. Thank you very much. [*Hear! Hear!*]

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Members, two minutes each for the commentary.

Prof Hamza Adam (NDC — Kumbungu): Thank you so much, Mr

Speaker, for the opportunity to comment on the Statement ably made by Hon Alhassan Suhuyini on our great alma mater. GHANASCO is one of the progressive and greatest secondary schools we have in this country. In the Northern Region, it is the number one. Although Tamale Secondary School students or alumni see GHANASCO as their rivals, we see them as mentees.

The Speaker: I am here— [*Laughter*—and we do not see you as equals at all, so we cannot be rivals at all. The gap is too wide. Do not go there.

Prof Hamza Adam: Mr Speaker, I am guided.

Indeed, GHANASCO has made a significant contribution to the human resource of this country. Hon Alhassan Suhuyini already mentioned a number of great people who have been produced by Ghana Secondary School, including H.E John Dramani Mahama and the First Lady, Mrs Lordina Mahama. Our great Leader has been mentioned as one of the alumni, and many others.

Mr Speaker, GHANASCO has nurtured and shaped the lives of many great academicians and great people in this country. I remember my days in GHANASCO. We had very great teachers who tried to put us in the right direction. Although we saw them as “wicked” teachers, I can tell you that today we appreciate them. The likes of Ababio and Abare were very great

personalities who were very popular in Ghana Secondary School.

Mr Speaker, as we celebrate our anniversary, I would like to commend the management, the board, alumni and all for supporting Ghana Secondary School. I want to end by congratulating all of us, the alumni and well-wishers, on this, our celebration. I thank you for the opportunity, Mr Speaker.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Member?

Ms Fatahiya Abdul Aziz (NPP — Savelugu): Thank you, Mr Speaker.

I rise to add my voice to this important Statement made by my senior Colleague, Hon Suhuyini. As a proud old student, I rise with gratitude. GHANASCO is not just a secondary school; it is an institution that has shaped northern Ghana's education and leadership journey for 65 years. It has moulded generations through discipline, character formation and academic excellence.

Mr Speaker, for 65 years, GHANASCO has given hope to children from all walks of life, especially those who might otherwise have been denied access to secondary education. Today, its impact is evident in this Chamber, where GHANASCO proudly stands as the secondary school with the highest number of sitting Members of Parliament. That is the legacy of national significance.

As we celebrate this milestone, it is important that we also look forward. GHANASCO needs renewed investment in modern classrooms, science and ICT laboratories, dormitories and a safe learning environment to prepare our young people for the demands of today's world. Mr Speaker, I join the call for stronger support for alumni, policymakers and stakeholders.

I congratulate the headmaster, staff, students and the entire GHANASCO community for sustaining this legacy. Long live GHANASCO. Long live Ghana. Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity— *[Hear! Hear!]*

The Speaker: We would take the last person. The Leaders want to contribute. Do you want to comment? Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Solomon Kuyon (NDC — Krachi-Nchumuru): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to comment on the Statement made by Hon Suhuyini.

The Statement said it all. GHANASCO, just as he said, is not just a school, but an institution. I am not surprised today by the calibre of people GHANASCO has produced. We are not just talking about this House that we have the highest number, but if we go to other sectors, in sports, academia and in all the fields, we will find Ghanascans there. GHANASCO is a disciplined institution.

I encourage and urge my Colleagues to kindly send their wards there for proper training so that they will have great men and women in the future. I am very proud that I was trained in Ghana Secondary School.

Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

[Hear! Hear!]

The Speaker: Yes, there is one other Member.

Dr Isaac Yaw Opoku (NPP — Offinso South): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, I just arrived from the office, and I am a little disappointed. First of all, let me commend the maker of the Statement, but I am disappointed that when he was doing the roll call, my name was omitted. **[Some Hon Members: Oh!]**

Mr Speaker, I am a proud old student of Ghana Secondary School. *[Hear! Hear!]*. Our current president was one year ahead of me. Her Excellency the First Lady, was my year mate.

5:19 p.m.

So, Mr Speaker, I want it to go on record that I am a proud alumnus of Ghana Secondary School. I had my Sixth Form education at Ghana Secondary School between 1977 and 1979. This

come too close to the praising myself, but I was one of the best students that year. *[Hear! Hear!]*

During our time, there were only two Sixth Form schools in the Northern Region, just two secondary schools: Tamale Secondary School and Ghana Secondary School. I am happy to inform the House that in 1979, Ghana Secondary School beat Tamale Secondary School during the Sixth Form, A-level examination.

Mr Speaker, Ghana Secondary School—*[Interruption]*—not that year alone, but I am being specific. I want—

The Speaker: Hon Member, the 1979 A-Level examinations was not a contest between Ghana Secondary School (GHANASCO) and Tamale Secondary School (TAMASCO). It is not a football match—*[Laughter]*

Dr I. Y. Opoku: Mr Speaker, the competition then was so stiff, and we were always competing with Tamale Secondary School.

The Speaker: So, if all those years, TAMASCO had better results and you only won in 1979, you should not be mentioning it. *[Laughter]*

Dr I. Y. Opoku: In conclusion, it is not in doubt that Ghana Secondary School is one of the best secondary schools in the country.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

The Speaker: The Hon Member, who was also on his feet, before I take the Leaders. Yes, two minutes.

Prof Seidu Mahama Alidu (NDC — Tamale Central): Thank you so much, Mr Speaker, for indulging me. I want to congratulate my Hon Colleague, Alhaji Suhuyini Sayibu Alhassan, for making this Statement. He has enumerated the great and illustrious sons that Ghana Secondary School has produced. Even in this particular Chamber, I think we have more than 10 of us represented here. That is a great testimony to the vigilance and the discipline of training that we went through as students.

Mr Speaker, it was not just about the calibre of people that we have and the quality of training that we went through. Ghana Secondary School also provided the opportunity for social bonding. The first family attended GHANASCO and met there. I also met my wife at the Ghana Secondary School. I can mention several other colleagues who have made their better halves at Ghana Secondary School. It is not just about the discipline and then the level of—*[Interruption]*

It was not just about the discipline and the quality of academic training that we went through. It provided an opportunity for social bonding, and we have all these great families and have been motivated by our better halves to do better. Mr Speaker, you are one of the best Speakers we had in this country. I am just wondering whether your wife is also a former GHANASCAN.

Mr Speaker, I take this opportunity to invite you, if you are free, to participate

in our activities this Saturday. I wish to thank the administration and then the students of Ghana Secondary School for bringing this school this far.

Thank you so much for indulging me, Mr Speaker.

The Speaker: Yes, Minority Leader?

Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin (NPP — Effutu): Mr Speaker, let me thank you for the opportunity to add my voice to the Statement on the Floor ably read by the Alhaji Suhuyini Sayibu Alhassan, celebrating 65 years of his *alma mater*. Mr Speaker, each of us here is a proud product of a secondary school. When it comes to that debate, it will be an endless debate. Down south, St Augustine's, where I attended, will always be debating Mfantshipim and Adisadel College as to which school is superior. It comes, therefore, without doubt that today, the Rt Hon Speaker, a proud product of Tamale Secondary School—I know Mr Haruna Iddrisu is of the Tamale stock. These GHANASCO people—*[Laughter]* Mr Speaker, just their 1979 win, they want to rub it in. Mr Speaker, you should have hesitated in admitting the Statement, knowing what was ahead. But as the democrat that you are, you want them to have their day.

One thing I pick from this is that our formative days in our various secondary schools are days that we must be very proud of. The teachers who played important roles in our lives. This is a 276-Member Parliament. Each of us has had the benefit of secondary education.

So, it is a moment to celebrate public secondary education in our country. Surprisingly, parents would pay huge moneys to private schools for Primary and Junior High School (JHS) education for their children. But when it gets to secondary school, they take their children to public schools. It tells one that there is something that our teachers in public schools are doing that gets every parent wanting their son or daughter to be a beneficiary of public secondary education.

Mr Speaker, while our friends are celebrating this day, let me also take the opportunity to congratulate all teachers in public schools for what they have done for Mother Ghana. At least they have made it possible for this Chamber to be populated by their own products. As for the aspect of the submission that Ghana Secondary School Old Students are the highest in this Chamber, it is a matter for another day. I will not contest it now, but I have my serious doubt. Because many of my good Friends in this Chamber, as I can see, are from GHANASCO, I will let them have their day. Let me congratulate them and wish them well and many accomplishments.

Thank you so much indeed.

The Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Mahama Ayariga (NDC — Bawku Central): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. In the spirit of reconciliation, I want to share my time with the Hon Minister for Education, who is the host MP for Ghana Secondary School, but unfortunately, he never

benefited from the very good teaching that GHANASCO offers.

Mr Speaker, I have very fond memories of GHANASCO as a secondary school. But to tell you the truth, when I was choosing a secondary school to attend, my first choice was TAMASCO. My first choice was TAMASCO because at that time, the headmaster of TAMASCO was my uncle, Alhaji Belko.

5:29 p.m.

That was the only reason. But my father attended GHANASCO. He was among the first batch of students who started the school. His schoolmate, L. M. Awuni, had become the headmaster of Ghana Secondary School. So, when I showed him my application, he took it, put it aside and said, “you are going to GHANASCO”. Indeed, all of us, his children, went to GHANASCO and we have never regretted.

Mr Speaker, I started practising law in GHANASCO. I had a small legal practice there. Any time students were invited to appear before the disciplinary committee, which used to sit, I think, at that time in the science block, I would go and hide in a corner. As the students went in to appear before the disciplinary committee, I listened to each of them and I told them what to go and tell the committee, so that their stories would be consistent and disorganise the committee. So, the committee was having difficulty taking decisions until they managed to get one of the students to confess that I was sitting outside all

the time feeding them and guiding them on what to say at the committee hearings.

So, my housemaster, Mr Kumah, who was an agriculture teacher, came to the dormitory one Saturday on inspection. After the inspection, he was addressing us and reported that it had been discovered that I was in the habit of hiding in a corner and managing the work of the disciplinary committee and making it difficult. That was the first time I heard the word “bamboozle”, he said “bamboozling the committee”. Mr Speaker, since then, I have not forgotten the word “bamboozle”. He made a profound statement and said, “I think you should be a lawyer”. That was what made me, later in life, decide that I wanted to be a lawyer, even though in school I was actually the best Arts student. My mother wanted me to go to the Kwame Nkrumah University of Science and Technology (KNUST) to study Arts.

Mr Speaker, as for the rivalry between GHANASCO and TAMASCO, it is what has really formed GHANASCO. We pride ourselves with being small, but with higher quality. When we talk about performance in O-Level and A-Level, TAMASCO would always sit many students. Yes, the story of GHANASCO is never complete without talking about TAMASCO. Mr Speaker and the Minister for Education know that. That is why, even in this Chamber, the story of TAMASCO and GHANASCO is that GHANASCO has produced more Members of this Chamber than

TAMASCO even with our small numbers. The only thing we have not done is to get a Speaker—[Laughter]

The Speaker: Hon Majority Leader, you know that what you were doing in GHANASCO was not practising law. You were practising something else, exactly what you are doing on this Floor—[Laughter]

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, as I said, I want to share my time with the Minister for Education, in whose constituency GHANASCO sits. I want to just conclude by saying that we are all very proud products of Ghana Secondary School. We want to urge the young ones who are there now to look up to us and be inspired to perform.

In all the secondary schools in Ghana, both the international schools and the grade A schools, if among all of them, in this Chamber, a school as small as Ghana Secondary School has produced the highest number of Members of Parliament, then those who are there in that school today should be inspired and to know that the sky is the limit. Mr Speaker, on Saturday, we will all be there, led by the President and the Minister for Education to join them commemorate the 65th Anniversary of the school. Thank you, Mr Speaker.

The Speaker: Well, Minister for Education, I am sure you will educate them on the statistics—[Laughter]. Well, they got it wrong.

Mr Haruna Iddrisu (NDC — Tamale South): Mr Speaker, I should thank the Hon Suhuyini, Member of

Parliament for Tamale North, for leading the observation and celebration of the 65th Anniversary of Ghana Secondary School, Tamale, which, without any debate, has produced the First Gentleman of the Republic in the person of President John Dramani Mahama and the First Lady, Mrs Lordina Mahama and many other personalities who have served this country in various ways.

But, Mr Speaker, Hon Mahama Ayariga knows that part of his attraction to GHANASCO was the *aduwa*. He was chasing some *aduwa*, waakye, which was very popular at that time. He was in GHANASCO because of *aduwa*—[Laughter]—He remembers that very well. Then *gablei*, which is called *tubaani* in Dagbani. Those were his attractions.

But, Mr Speaker, on a more serious note, we used to refer to Ghana Secondary School as Kuko Middle, a kind of middle school, if you would recall. So, Mr Speaker, this year they are celebrating GHANASCO at 65, a legacy of excellence, inspiring future generations. I am sure the number of Members of Parliament who are serving the Republic in various capacities and those who have made the nation proud in their service to the country would be there.

Mr Speaker, the Hon Minority Leader raised a significant issue, which should guide our debate forward. He made reference to Mfantsipim School, Adisadel College and St Augustine's College. I will even add Presbyterian Boys Secondary School (PRESEC) and

Achimota Senior High School (Motown); the rivalry of these institutions has been healthy and competitive. That healthy competitiveness has allowed them to strive even for greater excellence. We need to have more of those categories of school. Mr Speaker, it also gives a poignant position of how late education arrived in Northern Ghana. Mfantsipim School will celebrate 150 years next year, but GHANASCO is 65 years. We see a huge gap in terms of access to secondary education.

Mr Speaker, as he rightly stated, the President of the Republic, Mr Mahama, has confirmed that he will be the special guest of honour in GHANASCO on Saturday to join them celebrate 65 years. And also, to say thank you, GHANASCO, at least for the training which has made him President of our Republic today and he is now endearing to many.

To all GHANASCANS, we say we want to congratulate you at 65. Mr Speaker, let me conclude with just a translation of—[Interruption] Mr Speaker, I am just concluding on *Dania Suma*, which is typical in the Northern Languages. It is about good intentions, that whatever we do, we should let it be led by good intentions, which is what the heart does and not what the mouth does. We should be guided with good intentions in everything we want to do, even in our public service. I thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

The Speaker: Thank you so much. Hon Members, I just need a

minute to sign some documents and return, so I will suspend sitting just for five minutes. I will just sign some documents and come back.

5:39 p.m. — *Sitting suspended.*

5:44 p.m. — *Sitting resumed.*

The Speaker: Hon Members, please resume your seats. I think it is now time for us to move to the comments on the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, perhaps if you would grant me leave, I just noticed that the Road Fund—

If all Boards have been set up, it is almost a year, yet the Road Fund has no Board. Mr Speaker, I would raise that at the right time, but I felt that contractors, who are supposed to be paid— No, this is a legal matter. Contractors who have been on roads working are not being paid because the Road Fund has no Board.

Mr Speaker, this is a reset Government. Since January—

The Speaker: You are out of order.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Very well, Mr Speaker. Mr Speaker, you have ruled. He does not need to talk. He has to sit down.

The Speaker: Let us move on, please.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: But there must be a Board.

The Speaker: I am told three from each Side of the House have already had the opportunity to comment on the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy. The number four on the list of the Minority is Mrs Mavis Nkansah-Boadu. You have 15 minutes.

STATEMENT

Government's Financial Policy, 2026

[Resumption of Contribution from Column 76]

Mrs Mavis Nkansah-Boadu (NPP — Afigya Sekyere East): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to add my voice to the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana. Mr Speaker, I would like to join other Colleagues in thanking the Minister for Finance for coming to this House to present the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy on behalf of the Government. Mr Speaker, during the debate, I sat quietly and listened to my Colleagues on the other Side, and they have been quick to mention and talk as though we on the Minority Side do not support them or that it is our wish for them to fail.

Mr Speaker, I want to use this medium to tell them or to reassure them that we do not wish for them to fail. We actually want them to succeed. If that is to happen, it will mean a total erosion of the good works that H. E. Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo did together with the NPP government.

Mr Speaker, similarly, it will have a devastating effect on Ghanaians with everybody in this House affected, and that is not what we wish to see. During the presentation of the Budget, the Minister was quick to mention that the economy is breathing again. He said the economy was stronger and it was full of promise. Mr Speaker, I think the Minister is out of touch with reality. As we speak today, Ghanaians are not breathing any easier, utility bills are up, small businesses are suffocating and even leading to some of them folding. Mr Speaker, food prices are unpredictable.

5:54 p.m.

Mr Speaker, unemployment is at an all-time high, and this is the Government that promised to give our youth employment. The Minister for Finance was very long on rhetorics and very short on substance, especially when it came to the areas of creating jobs amongst our youth. In terms of growth of the economy and reduction in unemployment, if you permit me, I would like to turn to paragraph 1132 of the Budget, and it reads:

“To unlock round-the-clock productivity, export, and decent jobs under the 24-Hour Economy. We are providing an allocation of GH¢110 million in 2026 for the implementation of the 24-Hour Economy Programme. Mr Speaker, this will be leveraged with GIF, DBG, and private

capital to keep financing largely off the sovereign balance sheet”.

Mr Speaker, a meagre GH¢110 million allocated for the most touted 24-Hour Economy Programme. I want to ask the Minister for Finance and His Excellency the President what exactly this amount is going to be used for?

Mr Speaker, during the electioneering period, the President was quick to tell us that he was going to cure the problem of unemployment. So, then it was our hope that this 24-Hour Economy with a three-shift-to-one job system would cure it. Unfortunately, that is not the case. They mentioned there was to boost employment. We are not seeing that. My question today is that what the GH¢110 million Ghana allocation is going to be used for. Is it to interrogate areas where we need the three-shift system?

Mr Speaker, with countries and areas that have been very successful with the three-shift system, it is based on demand. I want to find out, have we already done that assessment? Mr Speaker, I ask again, have we already done that assessment? **[An Hon Member:** No] You ask the NDC and the Majority and they are quick to tell you we are starting with DVLA. I want to put on record that it started during the NPP's era. I can state on authority; I was in the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and we started with the three-shift system because there was demand for more passports. Then the eight hours was not enough so what we did was to do the three-shift system. So, if the NDC is telling us that with the most touted 24-Hour Economy Programme

that is the only thing that they can do, then they misled Ghanaians.

Mr Speaker, I want to find out, is it to incentivise the private sector? We heard communicators from the NDC Side promise that there will be incentives for the private sector for them to carry this initiative. Is that the case? Is this GH¢110 million going to be used for that? I have always said that it is not up to government to employ the entire population. You have to create that enabling environment for the private sector in order for them to create employment for you. Unfortunately, we have not done well in creating that enabling environment for the private sector. I put it to this Government to do better.

Mr Speaker, during the electioneering period, they mentioned that there was going to be some tax breaks; that there would be tariff reduction in order for the private sector to carry this. We do not see that happening. **[An Hon Member: Ao! NDC, *medɔfo adada me*]**—When the President attended this House, during the first Message on the State of the Nation, he mentioned that his Minister was going to shed more light on this 24-Hour Economy Programme in their first Budget. Unfortunately, we found zero expression in there. They were quick to say it was going to be in the 2026 Budget, but unfortunately, that is not the case.

Mr Speaker, whereas Nana Addo Danquah Akufo-Addo during his first year, created over one million jobs—**[An Hon Member: Yes.]**—Yes, and it was

through the NABCO and it is on record. You can find out from the platform of the Ministry of Labour, Jobs and Employment: through youth employment, through the planting for food and jobs and the likes, we did all that. It looks as though the Minority has been vindicated yet again. I can say that it was a mere fancy campaign slogan, and that the NDC has no plans of following it through. It goes to show that Ghanaians cannot, and I repeat, Ghanaians cannot trust the NDC.

Mr Speaker, if you permit me, I would also like to move to paragraph 1164 of the Budget. It reads, “to crowd in finance for women-owned SMEs. We are providing another GH¢401 million to the Women’s Bank”. Yet again another promise. In the 2025 Budget, an allocation of GH¢51 million was made to this Bank. Until now, we have not seen any disbursement. We have not seen any bank. But that was because to establish a bank in Ghana, you need not less than GH¢400 million. The Minority pointed that out, and the NDC was quick to do a U-turn. It is not surprising now they have allocated GH¢401 million for the Women’s Bank. I think I am right to say zero allocation was made during the 2025 Budget for our women.

I want to suggest to the NDC if they would to listen to me. **[Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Listen, listen]**—Mr Speaker, the NDC, under the leadership of H. E. John Dramani Mahama has only four years. One year has already been exhausted; he has three years more. To establish a bank, I want to find out, are we going to put up the banks across the

length and breadth of this country, all 16 regions, or is there just going to be one bank? How do our women utilize these funds? If the Majority will listen to me, I would suggest that we set up a lending desk in already existing banks to ensure that all the women in this country can access it and also utilise it. Our women from Kejetia to Makola are depending on this.

As I said earlier, we support a noble cause; we support anything and everything that will uplift the women of this country. But what we will not support is another *yenkyendi* agenda. We saw it with Savannah Accelerated Development Authority (SADA). We saw it with Ghana Youth Employment and Entrepreneurial Development Agency (GYEEDA). We saw it with the Brazil 2020 World Cup fiasco, Isoton, Bus Branding and the likes. We do not want the same thing to happen with this Women's Bank. H. E. John Dramani Mahama has promised and we will make sure that he walks the talk. We will ensure that he will provide the banks for our women because they are deserving of these funds.

Mr Speaker, that will bring me to the recent increment in salaries for public sector workers. We saw a 9 per cent pay increment for the public sector workers. The Majority is quick to support it with inflation. Unfortunately, that is not transcending into the market. We do not see any reduction in prices. Whereas the public sector is seeing an increase of about 9 per cent, foot soldiers who happen to find themselves at the Jubilee House under the fancy name of

Presidential Staffers are seeing a whopping 67 per cent pay raise. Are we trying to tell our nurses, our teachers, our public servants that they are not important?

Mr Speaker, as of 2024, DCEs were receiving GH¢5,000. That has also been increased to GH¢35,000. Are we telling the public sector that they do not matter? I think that is the information the NDC is trying to communicate. We have to do better; 150,000 nurses and teachers are at home because this Government claims that over US\$90 billion in our Budgets cannot absorb them. Is this the promise of jobs? I do not think so, Mr Speaker. As I said, the NDC has to walk the talk.

I want to state on record that even during COVID-19 we did better. While the whole world had come to its knees, with Ghana not exempted, we did double digits in increments in salaries. Unfortunately, the NDC is doing 9 per cent and they want us to praise them. It is not enough.

Mr Speaker, in closing, I want to state that the Budget was uninspiring. It smacks of joblessness. It is growthless. It is hopeless for the ordinary Ghanaian.

With that, I will say thank you for the opportunity to contribute to the Budget.

The Speaker: Hon Members, according to the list I have here, the indication is that the next speaker from the Majority Side is Hon Isaac Adjei Mensah.

6:04 p.m.

Mr Isaac Adjei Mensah (NDC — Wassa East): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to the debate on the Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana for the 2026 Financial Year, under the theme, “Resetting for Growth, Jobs and Economic Transformation” by the Minister for Finance, Dr Cassiel Ato Baah Forson.

Mr Speaker, I have been in the system for some time, but everything shows that this is one of the best and smartest Budgets ever delivered by the smartest Member of Parliament and Minister for Finance.

Mr Speaker, my Colleague on the other Side of the aisle, Hon Boamah, talked about the state of emergency. I thought that this issue was closed. The state of emergency has been handled by our Leader, and there is nothing to show. There was no documentation from the NDC front that called for a state of emergency during the NPP era. If there were some concerns by the public that there was a need for a state of emergency, it was because of the fact that the area was mismanaged to the extent that, I think we started this thing here, over 2,100 prospecting licences were given out.

When it happened, all of us were concerned because the areas in the 83 mining districts were filled by the Chinese with Changfans and that was the

concern. Now what are we seeing here? There is reasonable control. The rivers are becoming cleaner and better. The nine forest reserves have all been cleaned up, and we do not see mining in those areas again. The National Anti-Illegal Mining Operations Secretariat (NAIMOS) is doing well. The issue of the responsible cooperative mining is also key, and I thought this issue of the state of emergency was closed. Personally, I do not think that is something that we need to worry ourselves about now. There is reasonable control.

Mr Speaker, I want to make a few comments on the road sector. The Budget Statement and Economic Policy is clear on the kind of roads we have in Ghana in terms of our network. Hon Boamah talked about the Accra-Kumasi expressway, which I call the “Mahama” expressway. All records are clear, and indeed, when this project is delivered, it is going to be the best expressway in Africa because it is designed to be the economic heart of Ghana. The six lanes right from the Accra which is 198.7 kilometres to Kumasi, is the best that President Mahama can do for the Ashanti area as a hub.

I was surprised to learn that our Colleagues have concerns about that project. For the existing road from Accra to Kumasi, the Budget is clear that it is about 64 per cent complete, and there is nothing to show that this project will be

abandoned. There is a budgetary allocation of GHC4.3 billion for construction to the Ministry of Roads and Highways. So there is no trouble with the Accra-Kumasi expressway. It is something that is at the heart of President Mahama, and it is non-negotiable; it is going to be done, and that would be the best thing that the people of the Ashanti Region and the middle belt of Ghana, will inherit.

Mr Speaker, this is something that gets me worried when people outside of this Chamber think that the expressway is not so important, and ask us to hold on and go for the current one. As for the current system, I mean the network, it will still be done because there is enough budget allocation for that. We all remember the issue of the Kwame Nkrumah motorway. During that period, we are aware that some people spoke against it, but Dr Nkrumah went ahead to do it and today, it is one of the best for Ghana.

So, I think that this project is non-negotiable; it is not hopeful, but the determination of President Mahama to get this done. So we expect our Colleagues, particularly Colleagues in that area, to support it. When we check through the Budget Statement and Economic Policy, it is the first time, at least for my understanding, that a budget has been presented that gives clarity to

the road sector in terms of the national highways and corridor roads, the urban roads, the feeder roads and many more.

And more importantly, Mr Speaker, is the “Big Push”. So the Budget is very clear about the national highway and corridor project. This expressway, which I call the “Mahama Expressway”, is a six-lane road that leads to Kumasi right from Accra with eight interchanges. And the eight interchanges, we have the Accra Hub, Asamankese, Adeiso, Ofoase-Ayirebi, Bosomtwe and Kumasi. I have every reason to be happy.

Mr Speaker, I am from Ofoase and the last time I went to Ofoase, they were clearly happy and asked me to ensure that the President does not go back on his promise. I promised them that President Mahama is determined, the NDC is determined to give them that road because that is the shortest.

Mr Speaker, this corridor is going to provide about 30,000 jobs for our people. Apart from the fact that there are going to be eight lanes, there are also three bridges that will cover the Birim and Pra Rivers. There are going to be two toll plazas, one in Kumasi and another in Accra, and also, four service areas, where there will be restaurants and sports halls. So, this project is something that I think the other Side should commend President Mahama and request that it happens properly.

I made mention of the fact that the Budget is one of the smartest and clearest

pieces that provides details on our roads. We also talked about urban roads. Even for the highway corridor, apart from the Accra-Kumasi expressway, we have the Eastern Corridor Road.

Mr Speaker, the Eastern Corridor Roads are clearer, Dodo-Pepesu and Damanko are there, and it is about 64 per cent complete. Then we come from Elubo, Agona Nkwanta, to Takoradi. This project is about 72 per cent completed.

Mr Speaker, then we come further down and we talk about the bridges. The Budget may provide for 50 bridges and the locations are all defined and clarified. So there is no ambiguity. This is a Budget that is devoid of innuendos and sarcasms. Because in the past, we had the Year of Roads 1, 2 and 3, and nothing happened. This situation is now clearer. So there is no sarcasm, and it is much clearer. The 50 bridges are clear and budgetary allocations have been made for them, and we know where they are. Let us take two of them. We have the Volivo bridge and the Dikpe bridge on the Tano River.

There is also clarity on feeder roads. Thousands of kilometres of roads are dedicated to the rural areas, connecting the agricultural areas, and I think the World Bank is giving support for that and GH¢820 million has been dedicated to that. It is so smart and organised

because when our rural areas have their roads sorted out, it is economically beneficial.

There is also this issue of the GH¢3 billion that is allocated for 166 constituencies. I call these roads, “*ekwan nketenkete*”. These are roads that connect the rural areas by 10 kilometres, and that will do the trick. And budgetary allocation has been provided for that. It is clearer and easier to know that GH¢4.3 billion has been dedicated to the Ministry, and that is where our road, the Accra-Kumasi Road, will be sorted out. We have all the bypasses, that is good. It will still be done, but the priority, Mr Speaker, is the Accra to Kumasi Expressway.

6:14 p.m.

Mr Speaker, when we come further down—I need to be bailed because the Minority Leader is—

The feeder road situation is much critical. It connects to the agriculture production areas. But of more importance is the Adawso–Ekyi–Amanfrom Bridge which will connect to the Afram Plains where the real food basket of the country is. It will open up the area for commercial farming, that is more critical, and more commendable. We think that the other Side should show appreciation. It is better; we support this, and it is the best thing to go for.

Mr Speaker, I was talking about the clarity of order; right from the highways to the urban roads and to feeder roads. But of more importance to the situation is the Big Push. About GH¢30 billion is dedicated for the Big Push. It is much clearer. The Big Push we had previously earmarked 33 projects. Majority of them were those ones that were started by the NPP Government: Year of Roads 1, Year of roads 2, Year of roads 3 to Year of roads 5. All these things are brought together, and GH¢30 billion has been allocated for that. By 2027, the majority of all these roads will be captured.

Hon Member for Takoradi will bear me witness. We inaugurated the Cape Coast–Takoradi corridor. That is going to make his place super. So, when a person gets to the Elubo Road coming to Takoradi, that place is the nicest place to look for. The Hon Member has a very nice place. H.E. President Mahama is producing that and making sure that that corridor is sorted out.

The Big Push is clearer, and I think enough announcements and details have been given in that order. What else do they want to gain?

Let us have a look at the Budget. The Budget is much clearer, and that is why I said I am going to concentrate on roads. For the first time in our history, we are able to have clarity in our road definition. Once upon a time, there was a time that we did not know our road network. I had cause to come and challenge here. I

challenged that we cannot think and say that H.E. Nana Akufo Addo is the President that has constructed roads more than any other person. That is never true. On records, they are there. We provided the details, and the other Side could not challenge that. Hopefully and happily, we have President Mahama coming back again. President Mahama is making our roads better.

During those times, 2014 to 2016— it was better, safer, cleaner, sharper— that was the time that we had the upsurge of urban roads, the asphalt overlays. That is where we saw them. He is back again to modernise our roads going forward.

Mr Speaker, I think that I will encourage my Colleagues to have a look at the area, the section that talks about roads. It is the best thing that we can do for ourselves. President Mahama has commissioned his Minister. I am aware the Hon Minister for Roads and Highways took six months and toured all over the country. Every road and every corridor was determined, every network was determined, and now the Big Push is going there to make sure that our roads are safer and better. For that purpose, I think that we have a cause to jubilate. Going forward, we have every cause to congratulate our Minister for Finance who came.

Mr Speaker, the Road Maintenance Trust Fund has come to stay. Soon, I am informed, the board is going to be integrated. But the Road Maintenance Trust Fund is going to maintain our

roads, and that is going to do the maintenance for the 166 constituency roads. Those roads are the *ekwan nketenkete* that we are talking about. It is going to be critical. We are aware that most of those roads are their roads. Many of those roads are theirs, and we will ensure our roads are maintained.

When we took power, the records are very clear that the majority of our road network has broken down. For the first time, we have had the braveness to ensure that our roads are maintained, and enough financial allocations are made for that in ensuring that our roads are safe. We will not—By 2027, majority of our worries on our roads will be a thing of the past.

Mr Speaker, I think that this is so much good news that I am being harassed. This is harassment. In conclusion, I want to take this opportunity to thank and commend all speakers that congratulated the Minister for Finance for the wonderful delivery and what is in there, and also thank the President for such a big thing. The visionary President has come to help Ghana to move forward. President Mahama, we are so grateful. We are so grateful for your appointees, your Ministers. They are doing a very good job.

We think that the issue relating to state of emergency is gone. Kumasi-Accra—

The Speaker: Hon Member, your time is up. We will now listen to Mr Francis Asenso-Boakye. The Member has 15 minutes.

Mr Francis Asenso-Boakye (NPP — Bantama): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to comment on the 2026 Budget presented by the Minister for Finance the previous week on behalf of the President of the Republic, John Dramani Mahama. I intend to address a wide range of issues.

Firstly, violation of the Constitution and the Local Government Framework. Mr Speaker, my concern is fundamental. The Constitution and the Local Government Framework, the Local Government Act 2016 (Act 936), are explicit on the governance arrangements of the District Assembly Common Fund. The law is clear. It states, and I beg to quote:

“Utilisation guidelines must be issued by the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs in consultation with the Minister for Finance after the Administrator of the District Assemblies Common Fund has presented a formula and after Parliament has approved that formula.”

Mr Speaker, none of these mandatory steps has been satisfied. But in the Budget, the Minister for Finance, has issued utilisation guidelines and has unilaterally prescribed how District Assemblies should use their Common Fund. What it means is that if we allow this to stand, in effect, Parliament is joining the Minister for Finance in

breaching the Constitution and undermining the Local Government Act. If there is any institution that should protect and safeguard our Constitution and the laws made in Parliament, then it is the Parliament itself. But unfortunately, we are likely to join the Minister for Finance to breach the Constitution should this stand.

Mr Speaker, beyond the legal violation, this approach of the Minister for Finance coming to Parliament to issue guidelines using this percentage for 24-Hour Economy markets, this percentage for health infrastructure and this percentage for education infrastructure weakens the philosophy of decentralisation. Decentralisation is supposed to empower local people. The whole business of decentralisation is to allow the local people to make their own decisions, to identify their own priorities and plan for their own development. But this business of letting the Minister for Finance to dictate is centralisation, not decentralisation. It is not only unconstitutional, it is administratively regressive, and we must not allow that.

Mr Speaker, turning to the roads sector, one thing is clear, and you can see from my Friend, Mr Adjei Mensah, that the Mahama Administration is desperately attempting to match, or if you like, outperform, the unprecedented record of H.E Nana Addo Dankwah Akufo-Addo in the roads sector. It is the record that delivered 13,624 kilometres of road intervention in eight years, as against 4,636 kilometres delivered by

Prof Mills and Mahama Administrations put together in eight years. Mr Adjei Mensah was talking about bridges, interchanges and other road interventions. No government in the history of Ghana has built more roads, has built more bridges, has built more interchanges than former President Akufo-Addo's administration. That is a matter of record. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Speaker, we, from the Minority, have no difficulty at all for the present Administration, the Mahama Government, to emulate the record of the Akufo-Addo Administration. We have no difficulty, but the right thing must be done. In fact, it shows the standard we set. For they to be able to give priority to roads, it shows that they are copying our standards, and we appreciate that. But the right thing must be done.

What do we see? We see selective and misleading capture of ongoing projects in the so-called Big Push. While the current Administration has captured some of the important roads, ongoing projects, under the Big Push and in the Budget; the Ofankor-Nsawam Road, Kasoa-Winneba Road, Tema-Aflao Road project, as Ashaiman Roundabout to Atimpoku.

6:24 p.m.

There are a significant number of ongoing projects that this Government has deliberately ignored in the Big Push programme and in the Budget, including but non-limited to Jinijini - Sampa Road, Tarkwa-Prestea Road, Accra-Kumasi

Highway, Atebubu-Kwame Danso Road, Ahenema Kokoben and Anwiankwanta road, and the Kumasi-Mampong Road.

Mr Speaker, Hon Haruna Iddrisu recently went to Kumasi and he was complaining about the traffic situation in Kumasi. He thought Kumasi, being the second most important city in the country, should have better roads. The problem is the Government. Whenever the National Democratic Congress (NDC) is in office, they ignore Kumasi roads and that is the reason. During the President Mills and Vice President Mahama administration, for eight years, no important road intervention was recorded in Kumasi, apart from a minimal intervention that happened in Asawase, all because they had an MP there. The problem is the NDC.

Kumasi is a conurbation and a nodal city of Ghana, so when we want to tackle the transportation situation, we look at the spokes, the roads that lead into the city and we also look at the ring roads. The inner ring road was done by President Kufuor. When NDC assumed office, they ignored the rest of the projects. We did Kumasi-Barekese Road and Kumasi-Sunyani Road. Kumasi-Obuasi Road is under construction, but they have ignored it. Procurement started the Kumasi-Mampong Road before I left office, but they have ignored it. We did Kumasi-Lake Road, but they have ignored it. Hon Haruna Iddrisu, the problem with Kumasi is not because of anything, but because NDC continues to ignore Kumasi whenever they are in office.

In place of this omission of roads in the Big Push Programme, they have hurriedly put together a list of projects without feasibility, proper due diligence, and realistic price assessment variations. When projects are conceived in this manner, it is very difficult to deliver, especially within the time frame that this Government has set for itself. They want to complete all projects by the end of 2027; that is not possible. They cannot achieve that. Mr Speaker, from the way they have listed the projects, for me, it appears more like a political listing exercise rather than a credible infrastructure programme.

Mr Speaker, as I continue, I want to draw Parliament's attention to this troubling matter. As I speak, I have chanced on a letter from the Ghana Highway Authority to the Public Procurement Authority (PPA), asking the PPA to approve a list of 63 projects, all under single sourcing. My concern is that when the Minister was on this Side of the House, he spoke passionately against the use of single source. Now that his position has changed, and the Lord has blessed him and he is now the Minister, the things he campaigned passionately against, today he is presiding over one of the largest batches of procurement requests for single source procurement. Mr Speaker, the irony is striking, the inconsistency is alarming, and the hypocrisy is amazing. It cannot be the situation that when one's fortune changes, then their principles

change. It is not good. It undermines the work we do as public servants.

Mr Speaker, I want to come to the infamous Kumasi Accra Expressway. It is a question of prudence. This Side of the House is not against the construction of a highway from Accra to Kumasi. In fact, the concept of a highway from Accra to Kumasi was first initiated by the President Kufuor administration. That led to the dualisation of the Circle-Taifa Road, the Nsawam bypass, and the Nsawam – Apedwa highway, in Nkawkaw bypass and the Fumesua – KNUST dualisation. But when President Mahama and President Mills assumed office, for eight years, not a single kilometre was added to that dualisation project. In fact, the project was abandoned. It took former President Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo to revive the project, and start interventions in Osino, and Anyinam, Ngyiresi, and Konongo bypasses. The Ofankor – Nsawam road which is currently underway, is all part of efforts to support that dualisation, including the Pokuase Interchange.

Mr Speaker, the logical thing to do was for this Government to continue. But instead, once again, they want to abandon the project. It is obvious from what Hon Adjei-Mensah said, that the primary consideration for them to abandon the road is for President Mahama to start his own project and put

his name on it. That is not prudence; that is waste, and we should not allow it to stand. It is self-centred.

Mr Speaker, early on, the President said that the duration of the project will be three years. They said that it will start next year, and it will be completed at the end of the Mahama administration; that is less than three years. But later on, the Minister came to say that they are now hiring a consultant to do feasibility studies. If they have not done feasibility studies, how do they know about the design, cost and duration? Funding is not even secured. They do not know about the procurement process. How can they determine the duration of the project, which they claim is three years? From my experience as Minister for Works and Housing, I can tell this House that if this project is to become reality, it will not take more than six years to complete this project.

Mr Speaker, we all know that this Kumasi – Accra Road is the most important trunk road in the country. A third of the Ghanaian population use this road. As we speak, the road is in a state of disrepair. Contractors have been awarded to repair the road to help people to commute freely. The Minister has decided not to resource them, and the road continues to create problems, accidents, and affect productivity and all that, but he does not care. Maybe, it is because he, the Minister for Finance and the President do not use the road, and that the many people who are to use the road go by air. People who are supposed to take decisions regarding this road, they go by air, and the ordinary Ghanaians

who use this road are suffering. It is time for the President and the Minister for Finance to go on that road and see how Ghanaians are suffering.

Mr Speaker, regarding the Adawso-Ekye Amanfrom Bridge, it is a good project started by the Akufo-Addo administration. It was to unlock the economic potentials in the Afram Plains, we supported, and former President Akufo-Addo started important discussions with the Korean President to seek the Korean fund to finance this project. I am urging President Mahama to follow up on that, and he will get the money to finance this project.

Mr Speaker, our concern is about legality. It is about policy integrity. It is about accuracy. It is about fiscal prudence. Our duty as a House is not to rubber-stamp unconstitutional provisions and endorse infrastructure weaknesses that lack feasibility. Mr Speaker, we believe in transparency, constitutional compliance, and value for money.

6:34 p.m.

Mr Speaker, the Minority will always stand for what is lawful, prudent, and in the best interest of the people.

The Speaker: Hon Members, we will now listen to Mr Andrew Dari Chiwitey. You have 15 minutes.

Mr Andrew Dari Chiwitey (NDC — Sawla/Tuna/Kalba): I thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to speak to

the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana. The Budget is entitled “Resetting for Growth, Jobs, and Economic Transformation”.

Mr Speaker, I am grateful that I have to speak just after Mr Asenso-Boakye spoke. He spoke as if he just landed in Ghana today. He spoke as if he was not the Minister for Roads and Highways of this country. The Hon Member spoke as if his Government that just left office, did not rule this country for eight good years. He spoke as if Ghanaians had forgotten that his Government, of which he was a Minister, declared the Year of Roads thrice. Mr Asenso-Boakye spoke as if we had forgotten that he stood in Ejisu during the 2024 by-election on 24th April, and said: “*sɛ mo to aba ma NDC ni a, ɔrentumi emba me hɔ embe* lobby for roads”. To wit: if you vote for an NDC man, he cannot come to me and lobby for roads. The internet does not lie.

Mr Speaker, this same Hon Member, on this Floor of the House, indicated that roads should be constructed where we have human beings. To indicate that, where H. E. John Dramani Mahama's Government's decision to send roads to the northern part of Ghana does not have human beings. We are all Ghanaians, and we deserve better.

Mr Speaker, Ghanaians are wise; Ghanaians knew the reason they voted them out and voted for the NDC massively—

The Speaker: Hon Member, you mentioned his name, so he is up on his feet. Let us listen to him.

Mr Asenso-Boakye: Mr Speaker, the Hon Member mentioned my name in respect of two major statements. I think it is fair that I use the opportunity to clarify.

Firstly, in Ejisu, I never said that they should not vote—it is important that listen. There was no NDC candidate. NDC was not on the ballot, so how can I say they should not vote for NDC because they cannot—[Uproar] It is not true. What I said was that if they vote for an independent candidate, he will not be in a position to lobby for projects for them. That is what I said.

Secondly, I never said President Mahama should not send projects to the northern part of Ghana because there are no human beings there. I never said that. I was responding to the Hon Minister for Roads and Transport, who said that a big chunk of President Akufo-Addo's Road intervention concentrated in Greater-Accra and Ashanti Regions, and in the words of Mr Agbodza, that was not good. I was explaining that roads are built where the population densities are high. That is it. Stop the propaganda. They are dividing the country. They are using regional and tribal politics to divide the country. That is not good. It will not help the country.

The Speaker: Hon Members, I have noted the minutes, so you have not lost any minutes at all. It was on a point of

clarification, and it was permitted. So please, Hon Member, go on.

Mr Chiwitey: Thank you so much, Mr Speaker. I want the NPP side to be reassured that H. E. John Mahama knows what he is about. He knows that the people of Ghana voted for him massively, and so he is going to serve them the way they want him to serve him.

Mr Speaker, and let the NPP Members be reassured that the Accra-Kumasi express road in the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy will be worked on, and the dualisation of the express road will also be worked on. So, they should not be worried at all. We are going to serve the people Ghana. We are not going to look at people in the north, east, west, and south. We are developing the whole of Ghana, and that is the idea. That is what the people of Ghana want us to do but not to concentrate on some areas and leave out others.

Mr Speaker, there is this Statement in the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy that sounds so well for me, where the Minister for Finance indicated that they are devoting US\$10 billion. This is going to be an initiative that would translate into fiscal stability, fiscal progress, modernisation of roads, bridges, ports and logistics, corridors that drive inclusive growth, productivity, and job creation. This is an all-inclusive Budget. It is in paragraph 961. They should go there and they will find it.

Mr Speaker, this is the Budget we are talking about; a budget that brings

inclusivity, a budget that is going to connect us, and a budget that is going to bring jobs. If they do not like such a budget, what kind of budget do they want again? Those storytelling budgets and Bible-quoting budgets are gone. Those did not get Ghanaians the development that they wanted. The quoting of the Bible did not bring the roads that we needed. The quoting of the Bible did not bring the development in the education sector that we wanted. That is why this budget has come to solve all these problems.

Mr Speaker, another area of the Budget that I love so much is the farmer service centre. The farmer service centres that this Budget Statement and Economic Policy is talking about, in fact, under paragraph 954, the Government will import a lot of equipment to support the farmers; 660 tractors will be imported. 3,000 tractors and trailers, and the list goes on.

Gone are the days when we had a government that declared a policy called "Planting for Food and Jobs", where we never saw the food and jobs. Mr Speaker, what they did was to go and sell plantain, bananas and tomatoes at the Ministry of Food and Agriculture. This is not what Ghanaians want. What Ghanaians want is to feel development in their constituencies, communities and villages. These are the things that Ghanaians want.

6:44 p.m.

Mr Speaker, the Member who spoke before me indicated that decentralisation

is not being felt. Under their Government, when he was the Minister, even contracts under feeder roads were awarded in Accra. Patching of roads were awarded in Accra. We are going to see different things happening because now we are going to see proper decentralisation because DCEs will have jobs to do. Mr Speaker, 80 per cent of the Common Fund will go to the assemblies for the DCEs themselves to award contracts to contractors that are known to the assemblies; to contractors that are ready to work for the achievement of the assemblies. Not those days when we had contracts, simple contracts, school blocks, we had road patches, we had borehole contracts awarded in Accra and DCEs were sitting in their offices without any job to do. That was not decentralisation. The decentralisation that we all fought for is what we are going to experience now under H.E John Dramani Mahama.

Mr Speaker, another area that I want to talk about is the intervention in education in paragraphs 1047, 1048 and 1049 which clearly indicates the way H. E. John Dramani Mahama's Government is going to tackle education, especially at the basic level. I am a rural person. I come from a rural constituency, so I know what I am talking about. The basic level of education is being cut off completely. The concentration under former President Akufo-Addo was on the secondary level. Meanwhile, we all know that before you get to secondary school, if you do not get the beginning well, you get to the secondary school and you are hanging. And that is why under their regime, they concentrated on only

past questions to support the senior high students to write their exams, which was very terrible.

Mr Speaker, I served on the Committee on Assurances. During the NPP regime, textbooks that the Minister for Education promised, for about three or four years, Basic Education Certificate Examination (BECE) candidates never saw a single textbook before they wrote their exams. That is what President Mahama said we are going to tackle. We will ensure that we build a foundation. We will ensure that before pupils write their BECE, they are well trained, they get the textbooks and are well prepared. So, before they get to the secondary school, they know what they are about. We are not going to experience what we saw in the past nine years.

Mr Speaker, let the NPP rest assure that Ghanaians are going to keep them in opposition. I cannot tell you the number of years they are going to stay in opposition, because for all these things they are saying, they are people that we know. We have seen their works under President Akufo-Addo. We have seen their works when H. E. Dr Mahamudu Bawumia was the Vice President, when he championed the economic affairs of this country, when he used to come and sit in this Chamber and nod his head throughout the presentation of the budget. And we saw—*[Interruption]*—Yes, he used to sit and would nod his head throughout. If it is four hours that Mr Kenneth Ofori-Atta would present the budget, he would sit and nod for four hours. We saw and benefited nothing

from those budgets that were presented in white shirts and with Bible quotations and the head nodding.

So Mr Speaker, those days of stories are gone. Now we are in for proper work, we are in for proper development, we are in for the Big Push benefits which President Mahama launched recently. We are all going to benefit from it. I want to assure the Hon Minority Leader that the Road Maintenance Fund that he talked about, indicating that we do not have a board, it will not be long, the board will be set up and all constituencies will benefit from it. *[Hear! Hear!]* The formula will be brought to this House; Members of Parliament will have their input in such a way that at the end of the day—

The Speaker: Hon Member, you mentioned the name of the Hon Minority Leader, so he has a right of reply.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, Hon Chiwitey is my very good friend. Although I disagree with all he has been saying, I have been admiring him.

Mr Speaker, they have shared positions and he did not get one. That one, he is not concerned about it. He is not a deputy Minister. All these beautiful boards, GRA, Ghana Gas, Road Fund, Pre-Mix Committee—

The Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, you are out of order.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Very well, Mr Speaker, I will accept your ruling.

The Speaker: You may continue, Hon Chiwitey.

Mr Chiwitey: Mr Speaker, I am most grateful.

I am not worried that I am not serving on any board, but let me tell him, I serve on the Board of the Agricultural Development Bank, a board that the Hon Minority Leader ever served on. Mr Speaker, the bank that the NPP collapsed, I served on that board, and I want to assure him that we are going to turn things around—*[Uproar]*—Yes, I am on the board. Mr Speaker, the Budget has indicated that GH¢1 billion will be voted to revitalise that bank—*[Hear! Hear!]*—So be rest assure that we are going to turn things around, and the Agricultural Development Bank that they left struggling, we, the NDC, are going to revive it and make it a bank of choice again for the nation. This year's Farmers' Day will be sponsored by Agricultural Development Bank—*[Interruption]*—What is their problem?

Mr Speaker, the joy I have is that all of us, whether we are serving on boards or not, are all going to benefit from this Budget, so we are not worried, because the Big Push will benefit all of us, agriculture will benefit all of us, the retooling of the Military and all those things will benefit all of us. The investment the President is making in the basic schools will benefit all of us. So, whether you are serving in the Government as a Minister, whether you

are even an MP in opposition, you are going to benefit. President Mahama and the NDC Government knows what they are about. President Mahama wants to leave a legacy. He does not want to leave the country in tatters like President Akufo-Addo did. President Mahama wants to build the nation before he leaves, and that is why we have this Budget that is going to direct the development of this country.

So, Mr Speaker, we are all grateful to the Minister for Finance for the wonderful changes he has brought. Even his style of presentation, everything that he did on that day tells the people of Ghana that we are on course. Market women are happy and students are happy because most of them now do not have to get ready with school fees before they go to school. People living with disability are happy because they also have a share. Women are happy because they have a share in this Budget. Nurses and teachers are happy because they have a share in this Budget. Gone were the days when nurses were struggling for many years; they did not have the chance to be posted.

Mr Speaker, this Budget is a Budget of hope. It is a Budget for resetting the country. It is a Budget for redeveloping the country. It is a Budget that is going to bring peace.

I thank you for this opportunity. I will continue to appreciate my President for what he is doing, and I will continue to appreciate all the Members on this Side,

because we are all supporting the Reset Agenda of the country.

The Speaker: Hon Members, we will now listen to Hon Abdul-Aziz Fatahiyah.

Ms Fatahiya Abdul Aziz (NPP — Savelugu): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Mr Speaker, I rise to contribute to the debates on the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy presented by the Ministry for Finance which was in fulfilment of the constitutional requirements under Article 179 of the 1992 Constitution.

6:54 p.m.

The Budget, Mr Speaker, it has been described by the Government as one that seeks to reset the economy for growth, jobs and transformation. However, Mr Speaker, a careful review of the allocations reveals deeply worrying trends, particularly within the broad area of social protection. An area that is fundamental to improving the well-being of average Ghanaians.

But I ask this House, a reset for whom? While the Budget reaffirms commitments to gender equality and social protection, a closer look reveals a profound disconnect between policy poetry and the hard numbers of implementation. I contend that in its current form, this Budget Statement and Economic Policy fails the reset test for our vulnerable people—*[Hear! Hear!]*—particularly, women, children and persons with disabilities.

My intervention, Mr Speaker, focuses on key thematic areas that expose the budget neglect of the most vulnerable in our society. My argument rests on two pillars. First, Mr Speaker, the Budget repeats unlearned lessons of the past. And second, it makes new and dangerous omissions that will perpetuate inequality—*[Hear! Hear!]*—Let us not forget the promises of yesterday, for they haunt the proposals of today. The Affirmative Action (Gender Equity) Act, 2024 (Act 1121) was a headline promise of the last Budget. Yet, Mr Speaker, its crucial Legislative Instrument remains in limbo, only to be promised once again in 2026. This is not a delay; it is a denial of justice for another full year. Leaving women without a critical legal tool to fight systematic discrimination.

Mr Speaker, in the 2025 Budget, we heard of laudable promises of the Sanitary Pad Initiative and women in trade, but where were the specific budget lines? They were invisible, making it impossible for this House to track the money and hold anyone accountable. A promise without a price tag is merely a public relations exercise. The previous reporting celebrated output like we distributed pads, we sensitised people, but what about outcomes? Did absenteeism among girls actually decrease? Did the poverty rate decline due to the promise of the Livelihood Empowerment Against Poverty (LEAP) programme? We are giving activity reports, not impact statements. This is a victory of publicity over tangible progress.

Mr Speaker, in the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, transfers to social protection programmes, including the Livelihood Empowerment Against Poverty (LEAP), the Ghana School Feeding Programme, and related interventions, amount to GH¢3.46 million. This allocation is equivalent to 0.22 per cent of the GDP, far below international norms for low and middle-income countries. The African Union Agenda 2063 calls on Member States to increase social protection spending to 5 per cent of GDP by 2063. Ghana's allocation falls progressively short of this ambition and raises concerns about our commitment to reducing poverty and inequality.

Furthermore, Mr Speaker, the Ministry of Gender, Children and Social Protection, which carries a broad and expanding mandate, is grossly under-resourced. Its 2026 allocation represents just 1.1 per cent of the total Government expenditure, a level far too low to address rising vulnerabilities across the country. If we were serious about strengthening our national safety nets, the Government must increase the Ministry of Gender, Children and Social Protection's share to at least 10 per cent of total expenditure, consistent with practices in several African countries.

Mr Speaker, the Government's attention to child and gender protection financing remains inadequate. Two critical instruments, the Domestic Violence Fund and Child Trafficking Fund, have each been allocated only a million Ghana cedis, representing a mere 0.03 per cent of the Ministry's budget.

Even more troubling, Mr Speaker, allocations to these funds have declined significantly compared with 2024 levels. In nominal terms, allocations to the Domestic Violence Fund have reduced from GH¢2.7 million in 2024 to GH¢1 million in the 2026 Budget. Child Trafficking Fund has also witnessed a similar funding reduction from 2.1 per cent in 2024 to a million Ghana cedis in the 2026 Budget.

Mr Speaker, this sharp decline clearly demonstrates a worrying prioritisation trend. While the Government highlights improvements in macroeconomic indicators, it at the same time overlooks essential protection measures for vulnerable women and children. These minimal allocations are grossly insufficient for shelters, investigations, psychological and social support, rescue operations and rehabilitation centres. The Budget is mute on scaling up essential services for survivors of gender-based violence. We have a policy, but where are the funds for more shelters, for legal aid, for psychological and social support across all regions? [**Some Hon Members:** Ask them.] This silence is a defaming abandonment of our women and children in their darkest hours. [*Pause.*]

Mr Speaker, the 2026 Budget has allocated GH¢11.6 million to the Ministry of Gender, Children and Social Protection.

The Speaker: Hon Members, listen to her, please. You may go on.

Ms Abdul Aziz: Mr Speaker, thank you. I will take the paragraph again. *[Laughter]* I make the reference once again, the 2026 Budget has allocated GH¢11.6 million to the Ministry of Gender, Children and Social Protection for capital expenditure. This represents 0.36 per cent of the allocation to the Ministry.

Mr Speaker, it is important to note that a low capital allocation will mean low investment in welfare centres. This phenomenon will also likely limit the upgrade of social welfare offices, digital systems, rescue centres and shelters, which are essential facilities for social protection.

The Speaker: Hon Members, please, allow her to conclude.

Ms Abdul Aziz: A Budget is the most concrete expression of a Government's priorities. Its numbers, growth of the 2026 Budget, are promising. Its numbers and structure lack specificity and commitment. *[Hear! Hear!]* That is why we need a robust social protection system.

7:04 p.m.

The people of Savelugu and millions of Ghanaians, particularly women and children, cannot trust policy promises alone. They require targeted investment and accountable implementation. I thank you, Mr Speaker, for this opportunity. *[Hear! Hear!]*

The Speaker: Hon Members, the Hon Member was allocated 15 minutes. The paper I have here gave her 15 minutes, and she did not go beyond 15 minutes.

Again, Standing Order 119 says,

“A Member shall not read the Member's speech, to the largest extent possible, but may read extracts from written, printed or electronic documents in support of the Member's submission or may refresh the Member's memory by reference to notes.”

You are allowed to read your speeches to the largest extent possible.

May we now listen to the next person to comment on the Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government, in the person of Mr John Dumelo.

For whatever reason, you are given 10 minutes. I do not know why, but you are given 10 minutes. That is what I have on the paper.

Mr John Setor Dumelo (NDC — Ayawaso West Wuogon): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for this opportunity to comment and debate on the Budget Statement and Economic Policy, titled Resetting for Growth, Jobs and Economic Transformation. I would like to start that this Government is committed dearly and solely when it comes to creating jobs. When you talk about the oil palm sector, I have never

seen any government investing as much as US\$500 million to be able to create more jobs in excess of 250,000. When one goes to our neighbouring country, Ivory Coast, they are exporting over 650,000 metric tonnes of oil palm. Ghana is just doing less than 260,000. It is about time we focus on oil palm and other tree crops so that we can generate more revenue. I must commend H.E. John Dramani Mahama for this foresight.

Also, we are talking about irrigation for wealth creation. When we look at irrigation for wealth creation, and look at the Volta Lake, it spans over 3,000 kilometres. We at the Ministry of Food and Agriculture want to encourage all-year-round farming and all-year-round farming includes irrigation. That is how come recently we have taken delivery of the water pumps that the illegal miners are using, and that is what we are giving to the farmers in non-*galamsey* areas to be able to produce all year round.

The next one is the farm service centres. We are building 50 the whole of next year. Some of you might ask, what is a farm service centre? A farm service centre is a one-stop shop where all the farmers can get everything that you need. You can get tractors; two, combined harvesters; three, improved seeds; four, fertilisers; five, agriculture-extension offices; six, some loan facilities; seven, agro-processing equipment, and so on and so forth. My friends on the other Side will always ask, where are the jobs? If one multiplies the 50 by the number of people is going to employ next year, that

should tell them the number of jobs that we are going to create next year. Yesterday, I saw a group of them holding a calculator and trying to calculate something. I do not know what they were calculating. But if they can pick up the calculator right now and calculate the number of jobs that we are creating next year, just by the farm service centres, they will realise that this government means a lot of business.

The other important thing is that they are talking about allocation when it comes to most of our Budget. Have they forgotten that we are just 60 Ministers in Government, and they were 125 when they were in power? That means that 65 people are not Ministers. We are saving the Government and we are saving the country money. That means 65 V8s are not going to be bought, 65 saloon cars are not going to be bought, and that is what we call fiscal discipline. So, when they ask the question, where are we going to get the money from, we are saving, and we are saving for Mother Ghana. That is exactly what we are doing. Next time, do not ask, where is the money? Where is the money? Mr Asenso-Boakye asked, when he was talking about the construction of roads, that where is the money that we are going to use for this? Mr Speaker, the money that we are saving from even appointing 60 Ministers alone is in excess of GH¢400 million. Those are the kind of money that we are going to use for social intervention when it comes to implementing the Budget.

Mr Speaker, yesterday I was in the Western North, and driving from Sefwi Wiawso to Sefwi Bekwai to Adiembra, Nkotumso to Ayanfuri, and one would realise that most of the farmers are carting their goods from neighbouring towns and villages to the market centres. That is how come we are constructing 1,000 kilometres of roads to be able to help these farmers so that they can reduce post-harvest losses when it comes to selling their goods. Ghana loses over 30 per cent to 40 per cent of whatever it is they produce to post-harvest losses, and this Government is committed to be able to solve that problem. Something which the previous Government did not do.

The last but not the least is the famous *Nkoko Nkitinkiti* programme, which even the Minority are very much interested in. What is the *Nkoko Nkitinkiti* programme? We import a lot of poultry in this country, over US\$400 million worth. What are we trying to do? We are trying to engage each and every household across the country to partake in this all-important programme. So, we are distributing 10,000-day-old chicks. Some of them might say, are they day-old chicks? No. The birds are three to four weeks old, and so the mortality rate will be reduced. We are distributing these day-old chicks across 200 households in every district and constituency. That means that the whole of next year, 3 million birds will be distributed. That is how we fight the importation of poultry products.

Someone might ask, what about the anchor farmers? We are targeting 50 anchor farmers, and we are giving them 80,000-day-old chicks each for the whole of next year. *Wo mpe wei na wo pe deen?* Mr Speaker, we are committed to reducing the importation of poultry products. I must say, the importation of poultry products increased a lot when the Minority was in power, and that will not be adhered to.

At this point, I would also like to say that let us all come on board to support the Government when it comes to making sure that Ghana is on the right path. Let us sow the seeds of hope so that we can harvest a prosperous Ghana and a prosperous future. Mind you, the job creation is there. When the farm service centres are fully operational, we will require people to operate the tractors. We will require people to operate the combined harvesters. We will require people to be our great extension officers. We will require people to give out the loans. We will require people to make sure that the farm service centres are fully operational. We are not going to discriminate; we are going to give it out and start it in all the farm growing areas across the country.

7:14 p.m.

When it comes to fertilisers, we would also make sure that the right people are able to get the fertilisers. We are not going to give it to party members to keep it under their beds and grow their own plants under their beds. We would give it

to the right people so that the farmers would get the right amount of fertiliser.

Last but not least, when it comes to the application of fertilisers, we in the NDC are doing targeted application of fertiliser. We are not just going to distribute NPK to every farmer across the country. We are testing every soil across the country so that if it is NPK 15-15-15 that the person needs, we will give it to him, if it is 30-15-15 we will give it to the person, if it is ammonia or urea we will give it to the person. This is because we believe that in 2028, each and every one of us, as Ghanaians, will be able to feed ourselves, export and also feed the nation. Thank you so much, Mr Speaker. God bless you and God bless Ayawaso West Wuogon. [*Hear! Hear!*]

The Speaker: Hon Members, we will now listen to Hon Ralph Poku-Adusei. You have 15 minutes.

Mr Ralph Poku-Adusei (NPP — Bekwai): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for this wonderful opportunity you have offered me to comment on the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy. The more I sit and listen to the commentary from my Friends on the other Side, the more worried I become. I am very worried simply because the more we listen to the explanation they are offering us, as Ghanaians, the more we become worried for this country's future.

To understand the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, we have to look critically at the 2025 Budget Statement and Economic Policy. When

we look at that of 2025 and we equate the promises made in the 2025 Budget to 100 per cent, the reality is that not more than 30 per cent of the promises in the 2025 Budget Statement and Economic Policy were achieved. That is the reality.

Mr Speaker, I want to refer the House to paragraphs 146, 147 and 148. The relevance of these paragraphs that I have mentioned is that it sums up, according to the Minister for Finance, the achievements of the Government at the end of 2025. When we look at it, Mr Speaker, with your permission, paragraphs 1197 clearly has a beautiful presentation there. There is strong economic growth. They have indicated that GDP growth rose from 5.3 per cent in 2024 to 6.3 per cent, inflation dropped sharply from 23.8 per cent to a single digit, 8 per cent. When we come to the cedi, they claim that the cedi cumulatively appreciated from 34.9 per cent against the US dollar. It goes on and on with beautiful terminologies.

Mr Speaker, the question I want to ask the Government is a very simple one. When you go to my constituency, Bekwai, today, and when you go to the streets of Accra today, where is the evidence of these achievements in the pockets of the ordinary Ghanaian? It is a very simple analogy. They will tell us that they have achieved all these things: deep fiscal reforms, independent fiscal oversight, lower borrowing costs and debt reduction. The question I want to ask them is that which of these financial jargons puts food on the table of the ordinary Ghanaian? I do not expect that they want Ghanaians to believe

that restored investor confidence, where they say that all three credit rating agencies, Fitch, Moody's and S&P have graded Ghana's credit ratings, so at the end of the day that is going to put a roof over the heads of ordinary Ghanaians. That is not the reality.

What we have seen for a whole year is that a Minister for Finance came to this House to tell us his personal achievements, and that in his time he achieved all these things which are on paper. But the reality is different. Mr Speaker, today, begging on the street is becoming a profession simply because there are no jobs. Mr Speaker, when we pick this Budget Statement and Economic Policy, what Ghanaians were expecting to see as number one is that in this NDC Government, for the first year, they created one job. I would dare my Colleagues on the other Side to look into this Budget Statement and Economic Policy and tell us that at the end of 2025, the NDC government created a single job in this country. Mr Speaker, the answer is zero jobs.

Mr Speaker, I do not know whether they have Colleagues who are doctors in this country. I would urge them that if they want to appreciate the realities in Ghana today, they should ask their friends who are doctors that today in Ghana here, what the major cause of death in Ghana is. It is financial stress. Wherever we pass in this country, everybody is financially stressed. When we come to Bekwai, Odotobri, Nsawam/Adoagyiri and Weiya constituencies, they are financially

stressed. That is the reality of the situation.

Mr Speaker, when we have a Government that comes to this House to seek approval to spend 1.5 per cent of GDP on capital spending and at the end of the year, they come back and say that they have spent one third of the projected expenditure, what are they trying to tell us? They come here and tell us that they are going to spend money, we approved for them to spend it. Then in the end, they cut it in order for them to achieve one thing only; the name of the Minister for Finance who was able to bring 23 per cent inflation to a single-digit in less than a certain number of months? That is not what Ghanaians want to hear.

Mr Speaker, if the NDC government is minded, they should know today that Ghanaians did not vote for them to go to take the seat of the Presidency and prioritise their own agenda.

7:24 p.m.

Ghanaians voted for this NDC Government so that they can provide jobs for the good people of Ghana. Simply put.

Mr Speaker, but if one comes into this position as the Government of the day, and in the whole year they cannot boast of one single job, then this country is in crisis. Because Mr Speaker, without jobs, how do you expect people to pay their children's school fees, how do they expect people to afford three-course meals, how do you expect farmers to buy fertilisers, and how do you expect family

men to provide shelter over the head of their household?

Mr Speaker, let me be very clear. They cannot come to this House, tell us that they have achieved all these things, and that it is enough. Mr Speaker, it is not enough. This takes us to the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy that we have. If today they have come here and they are promising us 800 jobs—that is on page 145. With the permission of Mr Speaker, I read paragraph 1182, which states:

“Mr Speaker, the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government is specifically designed to create up to 800,000 new jobs”.

Mr Speaker, in one year, they provided zero jobs. Then they want to say that in the following year, they would create 800,000 jobs. Why? This is an unrealistic target. Mr Speaker, to give us some confidence, they should have even created five jobs, so that we will know that they are capable of creating jobs. Therefore, if they come and tell us that they are going to create 800,000 jobs, we will have some faith in them.

Mr Speaker, as if that is not enough, on the same page 145, paragraph 1183, this is what the Minister for Finance is telling Ghanaians:

“The GH¢63 billion road contracts awarded so far under the Big Push, will generate an estimated 490,000 jobs”.

Mr Speaker, let us do a very simple analysis. If you have GH¢63 billion, and you can use that to create 490,000 jobs, then it is fair to conclude that you need about GH¢100 billion to create 800,000 jobs. Mr Speaker, the Government projected revenue is GH¢268.1 billion for the year 2026, and over GH¢100 billion constitutes over 40 per cent of this money. When you look at what the Government is proposing to spend, there are some constants that cannot be taken out. The Government is to spend 5.7 per cent of GDP on wages, 3.6 per cent of GDP on interest payments, and about 4 per cent of GDP on statutory transfers.

Mr Speaker, the question is, if the Government takes all this money from the projected revenue, how much will be left? The Government would not even have GH¢300 million left. Yet, they say that they are in a position to create 800,000 jobs. Mr Speaker, that is untrue and impossible. It is unthinkable.

So Mr Speaker, I will plead with my Colleagues on the other Side, especially the Hon Minister for Finance, to come clean about the promises he can keep. They cannot say that, without money, they will create 800,000 jobs. Mr Speaker, it makes everything in this budget artificial.

Mr Speaker, let me try and conclude, because the more I go into this Budget, the more confused I become. I cannot understand the basis for this Budget in the first place. In conclusion, what I want to tell the NDC Government is that, the priorities of the Government today is at

variance with the priorities of Ghanaians, and they should reconsider their priorities. Ghanaians voted for them to go and do their bidding, and not their personal bidding.

So, in wrapping up, I want to tell the NDC Government that all that Ghanaians want is jobs, then we can take care of ourselves. [*Hear! Hear!*]

I thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

The Speaker: Hon Members, from my list, it is now the turn of is now the turn of Mr Charles Bawaduah. You have 10 minutes

Mr Charles Bawaduah (NDC — Bongo): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for giving me the opportunity to contribute to the debate on the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy that was ably delivered by the Minister for Finance acting under the instructions of H.E. John Dramani Mahama, the President of Ghana, in accordance with article 179 of the 1992 Constitution of Ghana.

Mr Speaker, this Budget contains several initiatives and policies that are intended to better the lives of Ghanaians. For me, the initiatives that is more important and give hope to the numerous Ghanaian youths are the areas that will create jobs.

Mr Speaker, you will see that in the Budget, unlike the NPP, under former President Nana Akufo-Addo, who promised and failed Ghanaians,

President John Dramani Mahama has made provisions for jobs for the teeming Ghanaians. If you look at this Budget, you will see that about 800,000 jobs will be created.

The Big Push Agenda alone is expected to create 490,000 jobs; jobs for the Ghanaian youth. Then, the establishment of three new garment factories will create 27,000 jobs for the Ghanaian people. Seven new agro-processing plants will also create 700 jobs. Mr Speaker, all these can be seen in this Budget.

Mr Speaker, there is a national policy on integrated oil pump development that will bring about 250,000 jobs in that value chain. So, it is clear that there are initiatives that will produce jobs for the Ghanaian youth. Mr Speaker, the area that excites me most is the Farmer Service Centre. The Farmer Service Centre

7:34 p.m.

It does not only have the potential to turn many Ghanaians into valuable farmers, but it will also provide jobs in terms of the operation of machinery, logistics, support, and many more.

Mr Speaker, then comes the several initiatives under the 24-Hour Economy. So, all in all, we can see that this is a Budget that will produce the jobs that the people want. Let me say that very recently, organised labour together with the Government negotiated and agreed on a 9 per cent increase in salary on base

pay and the minimum wage. Now that we are running a single-digit inflation, if this continues, and I believe it will, it is clear that we are not likely to have labour disputes and disturbances in terms of better remunerations. The effect is that there will be a harmonious industrial atmosphere. The economy will be calm and people will go about their daily work.

So, the NDC is not engaged in sloganeering, unlike my Colleagues. They came with so many slogans. One of their popular slogans was “One Village, One Dam”. “One Village, One Dam” was supposed to provide dams for irrigation. It turned out that they were dugouts. In a farming community called Dachio in the Bolgatanga East District, near my Constituency, Bongo, the chief described one of the dams as a football park. Then they also came with another slogan, “One District, One Factory”. “One District, One Factory” was supposed to establish factories in the various districts to provide jobs. We were told that a watermelon factory had been completed and had employed people in Walewale. Further scrutiny showed that the watermelon factory had not even been roofed. That was the kind of deception that they engaged in.

Mr Speaker, then came Pwalugu Multipurpose Dam. They told the people of Ghana that they were going to build a dam in Pwalugu for purposes of irrigation and for purposes of electricity. As we speak, they have not even laid a single block at that place. Then they came with Agenda 111 to provide

hospitals for 111 districts. At the time they exited office, by results that have never been heard of in the election history of this country, they had not completed a single one.

Mr Speaker, it is very clear that the Government of the NDC, under H. E. John Dramani Mahama is committed to keeping its promises, and hence the Budget that has been produced. So, I urge all Ghanaians that let us thank President Mahama and work hard to achieve the objectives of this Budget.

Mr Speaker, the way the Ghanaian people suffered under the NPP, the suffering, the chaos and the corruption would have even killed all of us before our time. So, I am sure that the way they are used to slogans, their last slogan was going to be, “One mortuary, One human being”. *[Laughter]*

Mr Speaker, I want to thank His Excellency the President for presenting this Budget Statement and Economic Policy and I pray that we work hard to achieve these objectives.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity. *[Hear! Hear!]*

The Speaker: Hon Members, we now listen to Hon Frank Afriyie. Hon Frank Afriyie, you have five minutes. He is not around?

Mr Frank Afriyie: Mr Speaker, I am here, but I am on this Side.

The Speaker: Very well. Then I move to the Minority Caucus and it is the turn

of Hon Nurideen Muhammed Mumuni.
You have 15 minutes.

Alhaji Nurideen Muhammed Mumuni (NPP — Nalerigu/Gambaga): Mr Speaker, thank you very much for this opportunity to comment on the Budget Statement.
[Pause]

Mr Speaker, I will take it again. Thank you very much for this opportunity to comment on the Budget Statement and Economic Policy presented to this House by the Minister for Finance.

Mr Speaker, let me—[Pause]

The Speaker: Hon Member, the thing is timed.

Alhaji N. M. Mumuni: Mr Speaker, thank you very much for this opportunity to comment on the Budget Statement and Economic Policy presented to this House by the Minister for Finance on behalf of the NDC Government.

Mr Speaker, my comment is on behalf of all ordinary farmers in this country. During the 2024 elections, these people at this Side, the NDC, promised the Ghanaian farmers, especially those in the Nalerigu-Gambaga Constituency.

Mr Speaker—

The Speaker: Hon Member, just for correction, you do not refer to your Colleagues as “these people on this Side”.

Alhaji N. M. Mumuni: Thank you, Mr Speaker. I am guided.

Mr Speaker, they made every single farmer in this country believe that if they get the opportunity to rule this country once again, the agriculture sector was going to be a goldmine. But today, farmers across the country are suffering. Farmers in Bimbilla are suffering; farmers in Dome-Kwabanya are suffering; farmers in Bawku Central are suffering; farmers in Pusiga are suffering; if we go to Yagaba-Kubori, rice farmers are crying. If we go to Nalerigu-Gambaga, maize farmers are crying. If we go to Tamale South and Tamale North, soya beans farmers are crying. It is all because the NDC is on a reset agenda.

Mr Speaker, during the 2024 farming season, farm inputs, including fertiliser, was very cheap [**Some Hon Member:** Eii! Are you a stranger?]. But these farmers are suffering because today, a bag of fertiliser that was sold in 2024 for GH¢450 is now sold GH¢550 per 50kg. And the Chairperson of the Committee on Food, Agriculture and Cocoa Affairs is here; the Deputy Minister for Food and Agriculture is here. The Majority Leader is here.

Mr Speaker, in 2024, a bag of maize was sold at GH¢600. Farmers were able to sell a bag of maize and pay school fees, pay hospital bills from the proceeds. They can even sell a bag of maize and buy five bags of cement from the sale. Mr Speaker, six, not five. But

today, if you sell a bag of maize, one can only buy two bags of cement. Under these people and their reset agenda.

Mr Speaker, I am guided again. Under my Friends, they cannot buy even two bags of cement.

Mr Speaker, during the 2024 farming season, if one sells a bag of soybeans, one can buy at least two packets of zinc roofing sheets.

7:44 p.m.

Mr Speaker, do you know that in the North, when one buys two packets of roofing sheet, one could get about three bedrooms as a farmer? But today, farmers are chasing buyers to even come and buy a bag of soya beans for GH¢300; they are not getting it. This is all because under the NDC's Reset Agenda, there is no money in the system. Is there money in the system? There is no money in the system.

Mr Speaker, let me take you to the 2024 Manifesto of the NDC. On page 20, they said they were going to do the Rapid Industrialisation for Jobs (RIJ). Mr Speaker, under that, they mentioned, they will set up an agro-industrialisation zone in every region. Today, I have in my hand the 2025 and 2026 Budgets. Mr Speaker, we are in the second year, and nowhere can we find a budget line saying that they are going to establish an industrial zone. This is their second Budget. We cannot find it anywhere.

Mr Speaker, you are from the Upper West Region. Have you seen any industrial park being constructed in the Upper West Region? No. The Majority Leader is from the Upper East Region. Has he seen any construction for the agro-industrial zone in the Upper East Region? No. Has Hon Rockson seen one in the Volta Region? No. Have we seen one in Pusiga?

Mr Speaker, number two, they said in their manifesto, "We will establish a mini-processing plant for cassava, tomato, fruits, and other commodities". We cannot deceive Ghanaian farmers like this under the pretext of the Reset Agenda. We cannot do this to our farmers who are the backbone of our economy. I am very sad today because I am a farmer myself. Almost 100 per cent of the population in the Nalerigu/Gambaga Constituency are farmers. They are going through hell.

Mr Speaker, number three, I read, "We will initiate plans to establish cocoa processing factories in all cocoa growing areas..." Our cocoa farmers, the ordinary cocoa farmer—It is too terrible. In the 2025 and 2026 Budget, there is no mention of the things that they said in their Manifesto.

Mr Speaker, when we go to number four, they mentioned, and this is very laughable, they mentioned that they will establish factories to produce local beers in the Upper East and Upper West Regions. The people queued and voted

for them. They said they would establish a factory to produce beer. Hon Majority Leader, as the Leader of Government Business, the only factory that this Government will establish in the Upper East Region is a factory to produce local beer. And after all, two Budgets, nothing can be found about those things.

I am reminding the Majority Leader and my friends in the NDC and President John Dramani Mahama that the people of the Upper East and Upper West Regions are waiting for their beer factory. Again, they mentioned in their 2024 Manifesto that they were going to revamp certain factories in this country, and that is the reason they are in the Majority today with huge numbers. They deceived the ordinary farmer into believing that by voting for them, their lives were going to be better. Not knowing that it is from paradise to hell. They said they were going to revamp the Zuarungu Meat Factory.

Mr Speaker, you have been there before and after two Budgets, and nothing has been said about it. They went on to sell the Pwalugu Tomato Factory. Two Budgets, and we still import tomatoes from Burkina Faso. Why are they doing this only in the Upper East Region? They even brought their deception to the North East Region, claiming that they were going to revamp the Wulugu Livestock Station. Mr

Speaker, we beg them, if they would not do it for us, they should not deceive us.

I am taking you to the 2025 Budget to expose some of the deception. And I am happy that the Deputy Minister for Food and Agriculture, as well as the Chairman of the Committee on Food, Agriculture and Cocoa Affairs, who is my brother, is here. Page 90 of the 2025 Budget Statement states, and with your permission, I will read, “In line with the vision to streamline agricultural activities for greater productivity and better returns on investment, the Ministry will establish 50 units of Farmers’ Service Centres, in all Regions and strengthen the technical capacities of machinery operators to support farmers, creating a one-stop hub for affordable agricultural services, machinery, equipment, and new technologies.”

Mr Speaker, this Budget is about ending. Have we seen any farmer centre in any region before? And in this case, they say in all regions. 50 in every region. Mr Speaker, 50 times 16 is 800 farmer centres in 2025. This is the deception that this Government, under their pretext of Reset Agenda, is putting farmers through. The farmers of this country must rise and realise that the MPs who are representing them are not doing their bid.

Mr Speaker, if you go to the same page, paragraph 523. It reads

“The Ministry, under the Transformational Grains Development Project, will procure and distribute 4,000 metric tonnes of maize seeds, 10,000 metric tonnes of rice seeds, 2,000 metric tonnes of soybean seeds and 200 metric tonnes of sorghum seeds. This is expected to increase maize production by 30 per cent, rice by 19 per cent, soya by 40 per cent and sorghum by 9 per cent in the immediate to short term.”

I have in my hand the 2026 Budget. This is what they said they were going to do in 2025 for the ordinary farmer, the soya bean farmer, the rice farmer, and the sorghum farmer. These farmers were so excited because that was the NDC's first Budget. They had high hopes and expectations, but unfortunately, today, they are suffering. Mr Speaker, I would recommend that they do everything possible. They should organise a press conference led by President John Dramani Mahama to apologise to the farmers in this country for deceiving them and also revise the Budget.

Mr Speaker, if we go to page 64, paragraph 431 of the 2026 Budget, this is what the Minister for Finance said. I will read, and we will make a judgment on whether they will be able to deliver even half of what they promised the ordinary farmer.

“Mr Speaker, aligned to the 24-Hour Economy, we launched the

Feed Ghana Programme in April 2025 to scale crop, tree crop, livestock and poultry, and agri-infrastructure. So far, 2,000 mt of hybrid maize seed, 1,000 mt of rice seed, and 50,000 mt of fertiliser have been distributed nationwide. In 2026, we will supply 4,388 mt of maize seed, 31,000 mt of rice seed, 240 mt of sorghum seed, 2,791 mt of soybean seed, and 272,000 mt of fertilisers to consolidate yields.”

Mr Speaker, so far, what they said in the 2025 Budget is that they will do 4,000, and they did abysmally 2,000 tonnes of maize. We do not even know, and we cannot trust whether the farmers got the 2,000 tonnes of maize or not. They said they were going to supply 10,000 tonnes of rice seeds. It is so appalling and disgraceful that out of the 10,000, they only distributed 1,000 tonnes of rice seeds to farmers. That is one per cent of the 10,000 tonnes of rice seeds. It is their Budget.

Mr Speaker, I want to tell the NDC Government, and H.E John Dramani Mahama. Today, they are doing *Nkokɔ Nketenkete*. For the *Nkokɔ Nketenkete*, we do not want to hear what we heard about the guinea fowl flying to Burkina Faso. We do not want to hear that again.

Mr Speaker, the Reset Agenda has affected our training colleges across the country. From 2017 to 2024, training colleges were fed three times a day. I

have one in my Constituency, Gambaga College of Education.

7:54 p.m.

Mr Speaker, this Government and this party swear that any time they are in power, training colleges will suffer. Today, training colleges are being fed once a day.

Some Hon Members: Oh!

Alhaji N. M. Mumuni: Mr Speaker, in conclusion, my assessment of this Budget is that this Budget is a QNET government Budget presented by a QNET Government. Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. [*Hear! Hear!*]

The Speaker: Hon Members, we now come back to the Majority Caucus and listen to Mr Frank Afriyie. I do not know why your minutes here is five minutes. That is what is written here.

Mr Frank Afriyie: Mr Speaker, it is supposed to be 10, respectfully.

The Speaker: Well, I do not have that. They say five minutes.

Mr Frank Afriyie (NDC — Afadjato South): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity granted me to also contribute as far as the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana is concerned. While at that, permit me to thank you exceedingly and also extend same appreciation to H. E. John Dramani Mahama for providing extraordinary leadership in bringing us this far. The

fruit of the sound economic management we are seeing and experiencing is not occurring in vacuum. That is the difference between the NPP and the NDC. It is as a result of leadership. There is a new sheriff in town who says that we must manage the little we have in order to make the most impact. I tell you honestly, when it comes to governance, we do not have a classmate in our Colleagues at the other Side. They cannot match us in any way and so I listened in amusement to the last speaker. Certainly, I believe he should be a student of Walewale Adam Smith— [*Laughter*]—Otherwise, I do not understand why you had inflation of 54 per cent and you claim farmers were buying fertiliser at a lesser cost. This can only happen in Walewale College, where Adam Smith was the teacher.

Mr Speaker, I tell you honestly that we have our Colleagues on the other Side maintain that in the last eight years, they have built as many as 150 factories. Yet, I tell you, the unemployment rate moved from 5.2 per cent to over 13.6 per cent. This can only happen when we are dealing with economists who attended the College of Walewale Adam Smith— [*Laughter*] Mr Speaker, I tell you honestly that today, what we are seeing is as a result of a proper coordination between sound economic management at the monetary level and deliberate fiscal prudence by the Bank of Ghana and the Ministry of Finance over the last 10 months. We have not made noise about unveiling and outdoorings with pomp and pageantry any Economic Management Team. We still recall vividly that in the last eight years, all we had were our

Friends reminding us of the Economic Management Team. Mr Speaker if you permit me, at every least opportunity, we were told the team was enriched with very powerful economists. Like, “What a solid team. Mr Osafo Marfo, Prof Gyan-Baffour, Dr Owusu Afriyie Akoto”, Mr Speaker, these were the bombardments we had. For the past eight years, it has been relentless corruption upon corruption. I hold here in my hand, Mr Speaker, the report of the Fourth Estate.

[The Hon Member held out a sheet of paper]

Particularly, with your kind indulgence, Mr Speaker, I beg to quote,

“...but five years into Akufo-Addo's Presidency, Ghana's best score in Transparency International Corruption Perception Index (CPI) is 43 out of 100. This is the worst Ghana recorded in John Mahama's era”

Mr Speaker, if you are a government and the worst in your predecessor's government turn out to be your best, then you should check yourself. Today, where we are, as a result of priority setting, the Mahama Government, in the last 10 months, has actually given to all district assemblies marvellous amounts of the District Assemblies Common Fund (DACF) account. Mr Speaker, I present, specifically, the quotation in the various municipalities. In Oforikrom, under the NPP's eight years, they had GHC1.8 million. In Mahama's time, they have allocated a whopping sum of GHC16.3 million. This is what we are talking

about. If you go to Abuakwa South, in the eight years, they had GHC1.6 million. Under Mahama, we have given them GHC9.6 million. These allocations are tied to projects. They are supposed to construct CHPS compounds and hospitals. They are supposed to build markets—

The Speaker: Hon Member, you may conclude.

Mr Afriyie: Mr Speaker, thank you so much for this leave. In Prestea-Huni Valley, in the eight years, they had only GHC300,000. Under the ten months of John Mahama's administration, they have been allocated as much as GHC8.8 million. Mr Speaker, this is what we are talking about, sending development to the base, in order to decongest Accra. We want to revitalise the economy at the base. We want to unleash job opportunities. We want to ensure that more of our youth do not engage in rural-urban migration.

The Speaker: Hon Member, I will take note of the few minutes left.

Yes?

Mr Dominic Bingab Aduna Nitiwul (NPP — Bimbilla): Mr Speaker, the convention in Parliament is, if a person keeps quoting from documents, then we can ask that person for source. First quoted from the Fourth Estate, we do not know whether it is true or not true, and indicting people in it. He comes and he is quoting—*[Interruption]* Mr Speaker, he is quoting a figure and claiming that in

eight years whole District Assembly received only GH¢300,000. In eight years? That I say is not true—
[*Interruption*]

Mr Speaker, he knows that there is no District Assembly in this country that in eight years received a total sum of GH¢300,000. It is not true. In fact, as a Member of Parliament, he should know, and I believe he knows, that the least a District Assembly received per quarter was GH¢300,000. Per quarter. So, please, if he is quoting, he must quote well. I do not have a problem if they give District Assemblies GH¢1 billion in their time. It is for them to use it. We will hold them responsible for the amount of money they give. But do not misquote and say that a whole District Assembly has received only GH¢300,000 for eight years. Please, withdraw that.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Member, the issue the Member raised is the source of your data.

Mr Afriyie: Mr Speaker, thank you so much. I hold in my hand receipts from the Ministry of Finance to the DACF Secretariat. This is the document I am using, Mr Speaker. Respectfully, I have quoted and mentioned two other municipalities ahead of the third one. So, which one is in dispute? Let me know.

The Speaker: Please, you make your submission. Do not invite him. You make your submissions. When he wants, then he will—[*Laughter*]

Mr Afriyie: Mr Speaker, thank you so much. The point I am making is that we

have realised that we have come to a point in time where there is huge housing deficit in the city, and a lot of youth have massed in the city without any work. So, the target, the aim, and the aspiration of H.E. John Dramani Mahama is to ensure that we send most of these youth back to base.

8:04 p.m.

That is why we will not centralise these monies in Accra, but rather send them to the various district assemblies so that we unleash job opportunities and incentivise the economy at the village level so that they can engage in productive services, grow food for us to eat in the city, and by so doing, decongest our roads of traffic as well—
[*Interruption*]

The Speaker: Hon Member, your time is up now, so we thank you. Let us move to the Minority Caucus, and the next person to contribute is Hon Lawrence Agyinsam.

Mr Lawrence Agyinsam (NPP — Hemang Lower Denkyira): Mr Speaker, I rise to comment on the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the current Government.

In these few days, I have sat to listen carefully to what my Colleagues on the opposite Side have been touting. They have been mentioning that GDP has grown by 6.3 per cent, inflation has come down to 8 per cent, interest rate has come down, depreciation of the currency has come down.

8.01 p.m. — [HON FIRST DEPUTY SPEAKER, MR BERNARD AHIAFOR, IN THE CHAIR]

On the face of the paper, I do commend the Minister for Finance for managing the economy of this country thus far.

But this is the thing. If we look into the Budget Statement and Economic Policy of 2026, on page 10—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, you are speaking for 15 minutes.

Mr Agyinsam: Thank you, Mr Speaker. The state of the economy in 2025, on paragraph 4, reads:

“Recent macroeconomic data on the performance of the economy confirm that: Our recovery is gaining solid traction as the economy expanded by 6.3 percent in the first half of 2025,”

Mr Speaker, if we go through this paragraph 54, 66 and 68, I want to tell my Friends on the opposite Side that there is no way in this Budget that they have initiated any new policies. All the indicators that they have achieved, the 6.3 per cent, the 8 per cent, is from the sound policies of the Nana Akufo-Addo and Dr Bawumia's administration. We signed on to the International Monetary Fund (IMF), achieved the staff agreement before this Government came to power. In the Budget Statement and Economic Policy, from agriculture, manufacturing grew by 6.3 per

cent. When did they, and the Deputy Minister for Food and Agriculture is here, import fertiliser into this country? When was he appointed? They came to meet all the fertilisers that had been imported into the country already. It takes some time to plant rice and to be able to develop poultry. So, if agriculture indicators have risen, it is because from 2024 to 2025, all these things had been done and they came to inherit it.

I recall in 2016, when the NPP came into government in 2017 and we said the economy was bad, they said we should fix it. They took advantage of all the things that we did in 2017, 2018 and 2019. We have been here before Mr Speaker, let me refer you the indicators that this Government left in 2016. [**An Hon Member:** Which document is it?] It is coming from the Ministry of Finance? Mr Speaker, GDP in 2016 was 3.4 per cent we grew it to 8.1 per cent in 2017. The source is data from the Ministry of Finance data. Again, inflation dropped from 15.4 per cent to 11.8 per cent. It therefore tells me that everything that they have done in 2025 was from the sound policies of the administration of Nana Akufo-Addo and Dr Bawumia. They came to meet US\$367 million from IMF and they have benefited from it. Agriculture has benefited from it.

Again, if we go to this year's Budget Statement and Economic Policy and I refer the House to the Ministry of Trade, Agribusiness and Industry on paragraphs 452 to 478. There is a deep concern for the Ministry of Trade, Agribusiness and Industry and the Ministry of Tourism,

Culture and Creative Arts. The numbers do not lie. The Budget promises industrialisation but if we check the funds allocated to the Ministry of Trade, Agribusiness and Industry, it is woefully inadequate. It is 844.

Mr Speaker, let me take you to Appendix 4A. In Appendix 4A, compensation that was given to the Ministry of Trade, Agribusiness and Industry was GH¢130,400,894 [sic]. Goods and services in 2025 were GH¢285,173,606 [sic]. However, in terms of releases, only—[Inaudible]—was given to the Ministry of Trade, Agribusiness and Industry. How can they deprive the Ministry of Trade, Agribusiness and Industry of goods and services? When they pay compensation, what are they supposed to use to run the organisation? They want to develop and transform this country without resourcing the Ministries that are the economic anchors of this country, and that is shameful and not correct. In consolidating their figures, does not mean that they should reduce the goods and services.

Mr Speaker, again, in that particular year, CAPEX was only a whopping GH¢8 million and nothing was given. Again, in 2026, the compensation was GH¢69,168,565 [sic]. Goods and services were GH¢267,146,281[sic]. How are we going to assess if they allocated GH¢285,173,606 [sic] and released GH¢1 million, and they repeat the same amount? That is budget credibility. How can we? It is rhetoric. It means we cannot

trust the Budget that has been given to us, Mr Speaker.

They went ahead to give GH¢200 million for garments, and here is the thing. In the era where African Growth and Opportunity Act (AGOA) has been cancelled, has been suspended, AGOA has been in operation for 25 years. And they say they are going to situate garments. Where are they going to export it from?

When we go to some of the policy initiatives that they want to do, and here I refer the House to Paragraph 482, under the Ministry of Trade, Agribusiness and Industry, this Budget is telling us that the Ministry is also working with the private sector and key institutions such as the Ministries of Health, Defence, Interior, Education, and Lands and Natural Resources to source uniforms and apparel locally, strengthening Ghana's textile and garment industry.

This decision, in our time, was that the then Minister for Trade and Industry, Mr Alan Kyeremanten ordered it through Cabinet. It has to be determined by the President that all state institutions must buy their goods locally.

8:14 p.m.

Again, they are proposing that this Government is going to produce jobs. It is laughable. Because in situating an industry, it does not take one year. To acquire the land or procure the machines needed to make the garment would take

no less than two to three years. By that time, they will be out of government. Therefore, the 250,000 jobs that they promised is not going to happen. It is not going to happen. It is the problem of Ghanaians, and we must tell Ghanaians the truth. These are just fantasies and estimates. So, to say that 250,000 jobs will be created is not possible. Because by the time they put up the building, procure the equipment, and begin to hire people, it will be two or three years and they will be out of government.

Mr Speaker, I then move on to the oil palm. I heard my good Friend and Brother, the Deputy Minister for Food and Agriculture, also touting that the oil palm production at US\$500 million. Yes, that is very good. It is a commendable initiative.

However, Malaysia has developed 35 products for their oil palm. Again, the seedling being used is not the same as the one being used in Ghana. I will recommend that the Ministry of food and Agriculture will undertake a trip to go and learn from the Asian countries as best practice so that we do not reinvent the wheel.

Again, for the jobs that have been promised, it takes four to seven years for an oil palm to be harvested. It takes three to five years, depending on the seedling, and therefore, it may even take three years. Assuming it takes three years, we are in year one, so all these policies will come to fruition in 2028. We must face

the reality. Therefore, these are the issues that I need to bring.

On farm service centre, we have been there before. How and when are they going to procure? Where are the machines going to come from? Are they coming from India or China or where? And when they come, how do they promise the spare parts for it to be used?

In Ghana, our land tenure system is different. We do not have commercial farms. For you to be able to use these things, it will require the farms, depending on the topography and nature of the soil, and the land. That is why when we wanted to do it, we had to take it back. Again, how are they going to pay? Are they going to be pre-financed, or are they are going to do it before they deduct from the produce? All these things are not in the Budget. So, the operational mechanism of how to do these things — again, year one, this is going to be problematic. They have to set cluster centres to service some of these trucks. For instance, if they decide to set up a centre in Mankessim in the Central Region, and I am from Hemang Lower Denkyira, and I decide to use the tractor and it gets put in that arena, how are you going to get it repaired for me to use it? These are issues that you need to think through and make sure it is a sound policy. But again, as has been stated, the implementation of some of these things is where the problem is.

Again, Mr Speaker, in this whole Budget, the International Monetary Fund (IMF) completion has not been stated.

Are we going to continue with the IMF? Or are we going to bow out of the IMF? It depends on— April next year. But again, this Budget is for 2026, and no mention is made of whether there is going to be continuity or not. If there are going to be any home-grown solutions, we need to know to make sure that at least our economy is in safe hands.

Mr Speaker, with these few words, I would conclude by saying that the office that the Minister wants to set up as Value for Money Office, although on paper it sounds nice, but as Obama said, we should build strong institutions, not to introduce bureaucracy into our system. Mr Speaker, I would therefore recommend that the Public Procurement Authority (PPA) should be looked at so that we would support them with capacity rather than going to introduce another form of creature called Value for Money.

Finally, I have news for —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member. Thank you. Your time is up. I will give the floor to Mr Sebastian Deh. You have five minutes.

Mr Sebastian Fred Deh (NDC—Kpando): Thank you, Mr Speaker.

At the risk of being time out because of the few minutes I have to clear my throat on the Budget, let me skip any other thing related to figures because the figures are so clear and they speak for themselves. The data points to the fact

that we, as a country, have strong growth. We have reduced inflation, and the cedi has been stabilised.

Mr Speaker, our fiscal discipline has earned us investor confidence, lower borrowing costs, and the ability to invest in bold infrastructure programmes like the Big Push. Indeed, based on the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy figures that have been presented to us, we as a country are confident that this can only be entrusted into the hands of somebody, and Ghanaians did this when they voted overwhelmingly for H.E. John Dramani-Mahama to steer affairs of this programme.

Indeed, I do not want to lose the very few minutes I have, but let me use this opportunity to correct an impression that has been created on this Floor that the NDC Government promises to create 800,000 jobs —and this, for me, is a medium-term projection. It does not mean that the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy would create all 800,000 jobs in 2026. This was said by a Senior Member of this House on the other Side yesterday. When I heard it, I cringed.

Mr Speaker, all these policies that we are touting point to one thing, and I will only focus on the agriculture and agribusiness policies. The African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA) implementation programme is one thing that the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy promises to uphold.

This is being done by rolling out a five-year trade sector support programme. You can find this on page 70 of the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy. Trade facilitation will see the light of day.

Mr Speaker, we will do export promotion and support export-oriented industries.

8:24 p.m.

They have heard H. E. John Dramani Mahama at the launch of the programme indicated that he is going to chair the Accelerated Export Development Programme himself. This you can compare to what others did in supervising the “big hole” that we have not too far from us. **[Some Hon Members: Fiasco, fiasco. Tell them.]**

Mr Speaker, other important policies and strategies include setting up of agro-processing zones, SME support, infrastructure development. Mr Speaker, for the palpable legs on which these will stand, permit me to use just two minutes to point out some fund allocations in the 2026 Budget: for agriculture, GHC2.2 billion has been budgeted; Oil palm finance window, GHC6.9 billion; Farmer services centres, GHC680 million. Agriculture enclave roads, GHC828 million; aquaculture development, GHC100 million. Buffer stock, GHC200 million; and of course, the 24-Hour Economy Programme would also get GHC110 million. Indeed, these are standing on intersectoral policies. I can also mention that this also

includes rolling out of programmes that will bring rural electrification to ensure that where we would support cottage industries, they would actually benefit from national programmes like electrification.

In conclusion, Mr Speaker, these programmes—my constituents—
[Interruption]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, your time is up. I will then give the floor to Hon Anthony Mmieh.

Mr Anthony Mmieh (NPP — Odotobri): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to the debate regarding the Budget Statement and Economic Policy for the year 2026.

Mr Speaker, it is undeniable that the Judiciary, the third arm of government, plays an important role in the governance of this country. It is the expectation of the Minority that the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy would address crucial matters—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Mmieh, you are speaking for 10 minutes.

Mr Mmieh: Mr Speaker, I am grateful.

It is the expectation of the Minority that the Budget would address crucial issues affecting the Judiciary in this country. But a good look at the entire Budget for 2026 only indicates that the Judiciary has been neglected in the entire Budget. Let us look at compensation. Compensation has gone up by 15 per

cent. Unfortunately, allocation for goods and services for the Judiciary is stagnant. A simple indication is that there has been an increase in personnel together with workload, whereas support for operation is stagnant. That cannot be the case.

Recently, several judges have been appointed to the Superior Court of Judicature. During the regime of the Akufo-Addo Government, several courts buildings were put up and all these courts are operational. It then means that the support needed to push the Judiciary is missing. No wonder when you visit our courts, some of them do not have computers, some do not have printers.

Even in some courts, furniture is an issue and that is as a result of the fact that allocation for goods and services is stagnant, which means that for the year 2026, it is going to worsen.

Mr Speaker, the total allocation to the Judiciary for 2026 is GH¢1.098 billion, an improvement upon 2025. But nobody should get carried away because, again, as I said, if you look at the problems facing the Judiciary, this amount is a paltry sum. If you look at allocation for CAPEX, it is GH¢120 million, which is woefully inadequate to solve the problems of the Judiciary. As we speak, here in Accra, there are justices of the Court of Appeal, justices of the High Court, who have been appointed, confirmed, who are at post working without offices. This is the first time that I have heard this. There are over 50 justices in this country who are working without offices.

Again, there are several justices, even justices from the Court of Appeal, from the High Court as well, who have no vehicles. Most of them were appointed and confirmed as far back as two and a half years ago. In March next year, a lot of them will be three years. They have no official vehicles. And it is all because the Government keeps cutting down on the allocation for CAPEX. This year, again, this GH¢120 million allocation for CAPEX is not sufficient to provide justices with vehicles. Construction of the Wa Court Complex has stalled, simply because the contractor is yet to be paid. Contractor has done about 80 per cent of construction, but he is cash-strapped. And this is what a handsome allocation for CAPEX would have done. Let us not forget that all these things I am mentioning, vehicles, and the Wa Court Complex, were mentioned in the 2025 Budget yet in the 2025, nothing was done about them. Again, they have been mentioned in the 2026 Budget.

It is important that we resolve these issues, because it is the Judiciary that is the custodian of our constitution. It is the Judiciary that is the anchor of our justice delivery system. And it is the Judiciary that is the pillar of development in this country. If other arms of government, which are Parliament and the Executive, have what they need, why is it that on a constant basis, the Judiciary continues to suffer? This is an issue that we need to look at. In 2025, the budget of the Judiciary was reviewed. I have a copy of

the letter signed by the Minister for Finance, titled 2025 Revised Ceilings for the Judiciary here in my hand, dated 24th March 2025, which is unconstitutional. It is an illegality. This document revised the budget of the Judiciary. It is against the Constitution.

If you look at Article 127 (4), (5) and Article 179 (5)—[**An Hon Member:** Listen to him. He is a senior lawyer]—it is very clear that the Executive can only comment on the budget of the Judiciary, but not to revise it. In 2025, allocation for CAPEX was cut from GH¢129 million to GH¢89 million. And that is why justices have no vehicles. That is why justices have no offices to operate from. This is a crucial matter that we need to look at.

If you look at infrastructure in the 2025 Budget, it says that three courts were commissioned, just three courts; one at Accra Metropolitan Assembly, the other one at Kpong districts, and the last one, the Winneba High Courts.

8:34 p.m.

This is woefully inadequate, whereas during the administration of the Akufo-Addo Government, in the first term, 98 courts and bungalows were built. During the second term, 120 courts together with 150 houses were built for the Judiciary, which shows that clearly this Budget is not a budget that is favouring the Judiciary. Something has to be done about it. And in that respect, the Minority wish to make certain recommendations

that, one, the goods and services allocation be reviewed. Two, capital expenditure (CAPEX) should be enhanced to ensure that infrastructure and the digitisation process are not stalled. Three, the Government should desist from reviewing the budget of the Judiciary. Four, to introduce a transparent monitoring and evaluation framework enabling Parliament to track value for money and real outcomes. And finally, to establish a clear implementation schedule for the completion of the e-justice system, which has also stalled.

When we talk of the e-Justice system, there are several phases of the e-Justice system. As we speak, the first phase is yet to be completed. It is still at 80 per cent completion. Meanwhile, in the 2025 Budget, the e-Justice system was mentioned. Nothing was done about it, or I should say not much has been done about it.

I am grateful.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, ordinarily I should not be doing this, but I think I have to bring it to the fore for the benefit of both Sides. He made reference to Article 179 (5) of the 1992 Constitution, stating correctly that the estimate shall be laid before Parliament under Clause 4 by the President without revision, but with a recommendation that the Government

may have on them. I have been a proponent of this idea.

The problem is that they normally fuse the budget of the Judiciary and the Judicial Service. It is the budget of the Judiciary, per Article 179, that must be laid by the President without a right to revise, but with comment. Now, the Judicial Service is under Article 190. So, the budget of the Judiciary can be cut like any other agency. Therefore, when you put the budget of the Judiciary and that of the Judicial Service together, it becomes very difficult for this constitutional imperative in Article 179(5) to apply. That is where the problem is coming from.

So, I advocated on the Floor, and there was a ruling by the Speaker to the effect that they should decouple the budget of the Judiciary from that of the Judicial Service, so that once it is done, the responsibility rests on the President to obey Article 179 (5) and bring the budget of the Judiciary without revision. So, the problem is the fusion of the budget.

On this note, I will give the floor to Hon Philip Fiifi Buckman. [*Hear! Hear!*] You are speaking for five minutes.

Mr Philip Fiifi Buckman (NDC — Kwesimintsim): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for this opportunity.

Mr Speaker, the Budget, as presented by the Minister for Finance, was very succinct, unambiguous, and understood

by all. As a matter of fact, the good people and chiefs of the Kwesimintsim Constituency and the Western Region have expressed their positive commendation to His Excellency, *Oseadeeyɔ, sɛ m'anhyia, Gonja ni dehyee* John Dramani Mahama. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Speaker, earlier speakers from the other Side spoke, and listening to them, I was marvelled. They want everything. In fact, they left office just a few months ago, and they want everything to be done within 10 months. Mr Speaker, they wasted and dissipated wantonly the finances of this state within eight years. The earlier speaker talked about the superior courts having no place, infrastructure or furniture. Within eight years, what did they do for the Judiciary? Thank God we have the Chief Justice, Justice Baffoe-Bonnie, who is here to change the shifts and bring a paradigm shift to the forward march of the Judiciary.

Mr Speaker, where did they build the National Cathedral? They destroyed houses which were occupied by judges of the superior courts. They have no moral rights. They should allow the venerable Hon Minister for Finance to chart a particular good path for this nation, as he is doing. It is not surprising that the morning preceding the reading of the Budget Statement and Economic Policy, there was a heavy downpour of rain. It signified the presence of God. It signified that God himself led the battle. So, Mr Speaker, if one comes to the Western Region, the NPP abandoned the

Kwame Nkrumah overhead in Takoradi. They abandoned the Takoradi Central Markets. They abandoned, for 28 years, the NPP ruled, 28 years, that they had Members of Parliament for the five constituencies, the Apremdo Central Market was abandoned.

Mr Speaker, it is interesting, when my learned friend, the Hon Member for Effia, spoke, he mentioned that there were no jobs. Tomorrow, we are inaugurating five major projects in his constituency—[Hear! Hear!] Mr Speaker, when they talk about no jobs, I ask myself, which job are they talking about? Because the “Big Push” has started, schools are being built. In fact, the Minister for Finance, after meeting the economy in intensive care unit (ICU)—In fact, they put the Ghana economy in economic intensive care unit. This man had to resuscitate the economy so that we would be able to put ourselves on the pedestal of growth.

Mr Speaker, we have many projects going on in various constituencies and districts. All statutory payments, which were in debt, have been paid. Many contractors have been paid, and they are all working. They are on the roads. The hospitals are working. His Excellency John Dramani Mahama came to the Western Region and inspected the Regional Hospital, which they had abandoned in Apemanim. And he has promised—If we look at the Budget, the “Big Push”, the Western Region is getting its share. The abandoned projects in the western region are getting their share of revival and completion.

The Effia Nkwanta Regional Hospital, the infrastructure, respectfully, it was also captured. Mr Speaker, what I want to say is that if we are able to carry out just 50 per cent of this Budget, by the time we are done, they will sing Kofi Kinaata's song, which says—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, I will ask that you stop your time.

Yes, Deputy Minority Leader?

Ms Patricia Appiagyei: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, the New Patriotic Party (NPP) has never been in power for 28 years. So I want to find out from our Friend to give clarity to the statement he made.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

8:44 p.m.

Mr Buckman: Yes, I am talking about the NPP Members of Parliament. In fact, they have occupied the five constituencies for 28 good years.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, that is the clarification. You have done the clarification, so move on.

Mr Buckman: It is interesting that instead of the former Regional Minister, who is the Member of Parliament for Takoradi, to applaud H. E. John Dramani Mahama for coming to give hope to the

people of Western Region, he was talking about kenkey, which was being sold at GH¢7. In fact, that kenkey is from Kenkey Boutique. He buys his kenkey at Kenkey Boutique. But those of us who are downtrodden and go to the open market, it is GH¢3 and GH¢5. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Speaker, the most interesting aspects of the 2026 Budget— In fact, when we talk about Budget, it is something that we are expecting to do. It is not what we are doing. So, it was a legal misconception, when one of the Members from the other Side rose and said that we were swimming in constitutional impropriety. It was a legal misconception.

Mr Speaker, the Legal Professions Bill, which is coming is bringing hope to the good people of Ghana. It would offer equal opportunities.

Mr Speaker, to conclude, I would want to say that every person, every single individual in Ghana should support this Budget in full force, in spirit, in soul, in morale, so that we will carry this Budget to the highest ebb and take it out of the abyss, which the NPP government put us into.

Thank you very much Mr Speaker. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we have exhausted the list for today.

Yes, Deputy Majority Leader, any indication?

Mr George Kweku Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, as you said, we have actually exhausted what we planned to do today in terms of contributors. I think we have been here for more than five hours, so we are in your hands.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: That is so. We have really spent more than five hours. Do you have anything to say?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Yes, Mr Speaker. We wanted to see if we can basically pray you to start tomorrow at 10 o'clock. Tomorrow being Friday and there are some important funerals to attend. So, we would want to start early, so we can finish early.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Is that the understanding?

Ms Patricia Appiagyei: Unfortunately, Mr Speaker, I am not a Member of the Business Committee, but I believe we had an understanding in this Chamber that on Fridays we try to start early and ensure that Members of Parliament attend to their constituencies. So, I support the idea that Sitting should commence at 10 a.m. tomorrow.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, on this note, I guess both Sides are *ad idem*. Fortified by Standing Order 56 (2), I will proceed to adjourn the House.

ADJOURNMENT

The House was adjourned at 8:44 p.m. till Friday, 21st November, 2025, at 10.00 a.m.

